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Teen And Up Audiences

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

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by Adertily

Summary

The call comes in at 5:27 pm, which, first of all, fuck that. Who calls a store three minutes before closing? But Catra's pretty sure if she's caught sending a homicidal stare towards the telephone until it stops ringing one more time, her manager's gonna want a word.

Or: Adora calls the local aquatic store for help with her new goldfish inherited from Raz. Catra's the one who answers the phone. Shenanigans ensue.

Chapter 1

The call comes in at 5:27 pm, which, first of all, fuck that. Who calls a store three minutes before closing? But Catra's pretty sure if she's caught sending a homicidal stare towards the telephone until it stops ringing one more time, her manager's gonna want a *word.*

Whatever. It's not like Micah's going to fire her, he's too nice, and she's the only one around here that's not got a dubiously shaped coral in place of their brain.

A customer's still milling about, mesmerized by the butterflyfish in the display tank as though this were a private aquarium and not an aquatic store, so she thinks she'll be late home regardless.

"Brightmoon Aquatics, Catra speaking, how can I help y—"

A hiccup, followed, unaccountably, by the sound of *sobbing*.

Catra narrows her eyes, tries again. "Um, hello? How can I assist you today?"

"Please, I need your help." All the shaky desperation in the woman's voice makes Catra think she'd miss-dialled the number for the local emergency services. What is it people do in this situation? *Would you like pepperoni with that, is there someone hostile in the room with you, stuffed crust or normal?* Catra shakes her head; it's been a long day.

Catra replies dryly, "Okay, what seems to be the problem?"

"Please, I—" Followed by a wet sort of snif fing sound, Catra reckons her face must look a state right now. Another hiccup. "I think my goldfish is dying."

"You." Catra rests her forehead against one hand where it's propped up on her elbow, she moves the phone away a safe

distance before muttering, "Jesus fucking christ." And then closer, more collected, "what makes you think that?"

"Um," They sound so distraught, it's actually a little endearing. "He's been swimming kinda wonky today, he won't eat. I don't know, he just seems super depressed."

Catra groans internally, asking between her teeth, "How long have you had him?" She gestures to Scorpia as her colleague approaches, indicating soundlessly to start the process of closing up the shop.

"Um, a few days?"

Catra begins to spin a pen in circles over the till's tabletop just to give her hands something to do. "And how long has the tank been set up?"

"Uh," A long pause, before, "a few days?"

Catra tries not to roll her eyes, though she's not sure why she feels the need to be polite when it's not like this person can see her. She runs her palm over her face. The last of the customers shuffle out of the shop empty-handed. "Okay, just a few more diagnostic questions for you. Do you have a filter?" It sucks that that's something she even has to ask sometimes.

"Of course," the reply almost sounds indignant.

Well, some brownie points there I suppose. "And what size tank do you have?"

"Um."

"Please tell me you know."

"I, uh. It was gifted to me."

"Right." The pen clatters to the floor, Catra lets out a deep sigh. "Do you know what your parameters are?"

"P-parameters?"

"Yeah, like your no3 levels, your temperature, gh, kh, *ph…"* She's being deliberately obtuse now because she's more than certain the answer is no, but anyone actually knowledgeable about this stuff will understand in an instant. It's a quick weeding process.

"Um." It's uncanny, Catra's sure she can hear tears welling up in her eyes again. "Just. Please, can you—" Another hiccup, voice wobbling. "Are you saying he could be swimming around in acid right now?"

"That's very unlikely. Look, what's happening is actually super normal, preventable though, for the most part." Catra calls it "dumbass with a new tank syndrome" though most cut out the first three words. "You just gotta do a few water changes, and maybe look at getting a bigger tank." Because, realistically, *yeah.*

"Oh, sure, of course, but uh, how do I do a water change exactly?"

Oh my god. She glances at the clock, one minute till closing, Catra might have steam coming out of her ears building from the pressure in her jaw. "Look, the store's closed, I don't really have time to—"

"Please," It comes out fast in desperation. "Finn was my grandma's, she. She died last week and he's all I have left of her, I can't lose him too, and I don't know what I'm doing but I'm trying and everything keeps going wrong, I don't know—I don't know what to do."

Catra's nails snag on the countertop. She should hang up, throw this woman in the direction of a few youtube tutorials, tell her to call back in the morning—but she's so audibly distraught it's actually breaking her a little bit. *Ugh.* "Where do you live?"

"Wh-What?"

"We offer an in-home maintenance service." *No. No, no.* No. "Where do you live?" *Why. The fuck. Are you even* offering*, Catra?*

"Uh, south of the Frightzone, Grayskull road." At least it's not much of a detour.

"It's fifty dollars for a call out." It's actually thirty-five, but they're also supposed to book in advance and it's also grunt work that she usually shoves on Kyle.

The woman on the other end of the line answers too easily. "Okay."

"Okay?"

"Please hurry."

The front door of the apartment opens to blonde hair and very red-stained, blue eyes. "Hi."

"Hi." Catra parrots, her voice comes out more husky than she intends so she clears her throat.

"You're the fish lady?"

Catra makes a clicking sound with the corner of her jaw. "That's me." She confirms, reshuffling the backpack strung over one shoulder. "Name's Catra"

The blonde blinks numbly at her.

"You gonna let me in or what?"

"Sorry , I just"…

Catra raises an eyebrow. "Just...?"

"W asn't expecting." Catra's other eyebrow joins the first. She knows fish keeping isn't exactly the most sexy hobby, but she thinks she's being a little bit too thoroughly observed for what's polite here. She's still in her work clothes, her hair's half up and she'd opted for her glasses over the hassle of contacts that morning, still, she'd bet she looks more put together than the tear-stained cheeks in front of her. Then, the woman's attention settles back on her face. "Y our eyes..."

"Y eah. I have eyes, they're different colours. Get over it." Catra looks away before pushing past her into the entrance, or else they might be stuck out here on the porch for half an hour and she's pretty sure the forecast is for rain. "Finn?"

"He's-" the blonde stammers. "He's through here." Leading like she's suddenly remembered why Catra was standing in her doorway in the first place, "I got back from work and I just found him like this."

The tank isn't atrociously small, but it definitely needs an upgrade. Catra finds a single orange and white fantail staring back at her with vacant eyes in water that's starting to cloud. The substrate's bright pink pebbles, and the silhouette of a castle behind is the only standing ornament.

As aquascapes go, it's a sin.

"Right," Catra declares, dropping her backpack of emergency supplies onto the floor and begins to rummage through them. "T ake this," She pushes a tub of Ben and Jerry's into the blonde's hands, it's starting to defrost a little on the outside. "Gi ve me your phone."

"What?" The reaction makes Catra pause for a second, she knows this isn't exactly a white picket fence, meticulously cut lawn sort of a neighbourhood, but it's also far from a pretend to be a ~~(~~what had

she called her? *fish lady*, just so she could get through the front door and rob her of her valuables.

"Your phone. Gimme. So I can hook you up with some decent youtube channels to learn your shit from while you," She points to the ice cream- "eat that, and chill out for a few minutes."

"Oh," She's a little bit slow and distant, Catra's picking up, but she hands her phone over after fumbling through her pockets for it. "My name's Adora, by the way."

"Nice to meet you, now sit down," She gestures to the couch, "and let me do my thing."

Catra sets to work. Arranging the contents of her bag onto the old, stained coffee table in the centre of the room. There's no tv here, she notes. The furniture's all pointed towards the tank.

Taking a sample of Finn's water with a sanitised pipette, she fills five vials up to the guideline, kneeling before the table. This probably makes her look more like a chemistry nerd than a marine biology graduate but whatever, so long as it makes the glasses on her face look less out of place, she can play the part.

Adora, to her credit, sits. She goes to the kitchen to fetch a spoon first, but Catra can forgive that diversion. Adora's halfway through the first video on the nitrogen cycle when Catra realises she can no longer hear the occasional sound of sniffing. *Good, the ice cream is working.*

"That looks really complicated," Adora pipes up eventually, timid, her attention following Catra's hands.

"It's really not," Catra reassures. "You know how to count right?" she asks, watching as the ammonia indicator bottle no.2 lets out one, two, three drops.

"I mean, yeah."

"Good for you, princess. Then you could figure this out in no time." Catra sends her a wink, and if the way Adora's eyes widen just as faintly as the blush on her cheeks is any indication, it's pulled her out of her haze a little. "Besides, once this mess is stabilized you can probably get away without the alchemy kit." She calls it that because it might as well be, from the way Adora's eyeing it.

Catra sets the five-minute timer on her phone, scrolling through her news feed until it tings. She's normally the last to volunteer for maintenance service, being in strangers houses like this is really fucking awkward at the best of times, and the way Adora keeps blatantly glancing towards her face that's probably unflatteringly illuminated by her phone screen should make it more so. It's not at all though, weirdly. It should be, because Adora's been, like, *obviously* crying, and it's dead quiet aside from the hum of the tank's filter and the narration from the videos in Adora's lap.

But it's companionable, in a really bizarre sort of a way. Catra's never been a very good judge of these sorts of things though so maybe she's just reading the room all wrong.

The timer goes off.

The colours in the vials, unsurprisingly, are all the wrong shades of ideal. "I'm gonna do a water change," she announces, standing. "And then I'm gonna do another one. And tomorrow I'm gonna come back and I'm gonna watch *you* do one, you understand?"

Adora pales.

"I'll teach you, dummy. And I'll leave you with more videos as homework, but listen to me," She approaches the couch as she hears the end of the video, and witnesses Adora ready to click the next one from over her shoulder. Adora, in a beautiful bit of miscommunication, raises a spoonful of ice cream in Catra's direction when she tilts down to tap at the screen, as though about to mindlessly feed it to her. Bless her. Catra might be fine sticking an arm in this woman's fish tank but she doesn't think they're at sharing

spoons yet. "No. Listen to me. *Only* the videos I recommend, got it? There's some really fucking bad, bullshit, outdated advice out there."

"Yeah, I got it." Adora swallows, lowering her hands into her lap. Allowing Catra to select the next link without complaint, she sticks the spoon in her own mouth and hums a little.

"Alright then," Catra pulls her sleeves up to her elbows.

"Hey, Finn." Adora greets the now notably more lively goldfish, her face pressed close to the glass as she watches him shimmy through the water, her breath steams against the side of it, before she's turning away. "Will he be okay now?"

Catra joins her, though doesn't get quite so close, her arms fold non threateningly within one another. "Your problem was with the water, not the fish. And no, it's not fixed, but it's being managed now and he should be fine. From what you've said, it sounds like a partial crash and not a whole new cycle so that should speed up the process."

Adora grimances visibly, straightening as she turns to Catra. "I wish I understood what that meant."

"Aw, don't worry, you'll get there." Catra pats the top of her hair poof in only partial mock sympathy. "You've got my number till then, read the things I sent you, he'll be good for a little while."

"Thank you for the ice cream and, um, everything else too." Adora smiles the faintest amount.

Something about it stirs deep within Catra's chest, moving all the way up to her cheeks in a trail of pink warmth. So she says, "It's the

way, Finn is the most stupid, unimaginative name for a fish I have ever heard."

But Adora's responding pout doesn't help to lessen the feeling. Catra ducks her head to her phone, it's nearly seven, Scorpia will be worried if she doesn't show up soon. She'll call on the drive home. "I should go." She wiggles her phone in Adora's line of sight as though she needs a justification. "My roommate is making tacos tonight."

"Oh, shit, right, sorry for keeping you from dinner."

Catra shrugs nonchalantly. "It's alright." Her stomach's been threatening to growl for the last half an hour, however.

Adora grows frown lines over her forehead as though she's forgotten something, but Catra's already packing away the last of her stuff, swinging her bag back over her shoulder. "Goodbye, Finn." Naturally, he ignores her. She lets her voice drop minutely before she says, "bye, Adora."

"Bye, uh," She gives a sheepish wave- "Same- Same time tomorrow?"

"Yeah, tomorrow." She'll send Kyle. Probably. "See you around."

Adora shows up at the shop the next day. Like, *unannounced*.

Catra's already busy trying to explain to a customer why it's a really fucking bad idea to keep multiple male betta's together and no, it doesn't matter how big the tank is, don't test me you goddamn moron. (All in her head, mind you, her customer service persona is one hell of an actor.)

She shoots a glare toward Scorpia who's sat a short distance away behind the tills, but the familiar, amused reply does not greet her. Scorpia's attention is on a blonde emerging through the front door, and it takes Catra a split second to confirm it's not Perfuma.

Adora surveys the room slowly, and then her gaze falls on Catra like a lost sailor finding the north star. She beams, followed by a tiny wave.

Something causes Catra's limbs to untense and her jaw to release, before she turns back to her current headache. Replying gruffly, "If you try to buy more than one from us, we will refuse the sale." Then she turns on her heels toward Adora.

"Hi." There's that warm smile again.

"Feeling better?" Catra asks. Her eyes snag a little over Adora's attire, namely on the pink and orange rainbow badge that's pinned to the pocket of her denim jacket.

Huh.

"Yeah, thanks for last night." Scorpia lets out a nearly inaudible squeaking sound to their left at that reply. Adora doesnt seem to notice. "Finn's good too."

"Glad to hear it."

Adora begins a mission fetching something from deep within her right pocket, Catra might still be mulling over the pin too much to query the motion. "I forgot to give you this yesterday." It's a whole-ass *fifty-dollar bill.* Catra blinks at it a few times as Adora holds it up for her to take. "Sorry about that, but I uh, also wanted to see you again, uh, pfft, obviously because you mentioned needing to upgrade to a bigger tank and I thought you might be able to point me in, um, the right direction." Adora's cheeks have gone a little pink. Catra will forgive her though because she's pretty sure her cheeks have too.

Adora’s arm hangs there awkwardly. Catra doesn't reach for the bill, she does, however, pivot her head toward Scorpia as though she’s asking for help. Unhelpfully, Scorpia’s watching them all moon-eyed.

Her best friend sends her an expression that loosely translates to ‘any news you want to share with me, wildcat?’ and Catra’s tilt of her head in return means ‘go deal with gladiator death-match over there and maybe I’ll catch you up later.’ Scorpia leaves them unobserved.

Adora shuffles on her feet. Catra gingerly takes the money, only because she’s certain the earnestness on Adora’s face won’t let her say no. She slips it into her back pocket.

“You still coming over later?” Adora questions, her hands pulling at the hemline of her t-shirt a little. Catra’s line of sight flickers back to the badge again and she thinks Adora notices this time. “Because I was thinking, since you were late having dinner yesterday that we could, uh, if you wanted to, of course, it’s completely up to you, but I wondered if you wanted to have dinner with, uh, with me?” She starts to deflate partway through like a pufferfish, it’s probably because of the way Catra’s dead silent and staring at her. “Just something casual, takeout, or…something.”

Yeah, no way is she sending Kyle. “Sure,” she clears her throat when it comes out raspier than she intended. “Yeah, that sounds nice.”

“Cool,” Adora lights up. “Awesome. Okay, cool.”

“Cool,” Catra returns the smile, before gesturing over her shoulder deeper into the shop. “Thanks?”

“Please.”

"You know you can get one second-hand for like, a tenth of the price right?" Catra's certain in any other retail position her saleswoman skills would have had her sacked months ago, but Micah's always encouraged education over profits so she knows she'll be forgiven.

Adora lets slip that cute little pout again. "I want the best for Finn. And I have the money since...um." She stalls, almost stops walking, even. "I have the money."

"Okay," Catra doesn't press again. She pauses them in front of one of the preassembled, oak cabinet kits. "Well, this bad boy," she slaps the lid- "can fit a whole forty gallons, enough space for Finn to have a friend if you wanted." Adora's face goes white as a ghost when she catches sight of the price tag. "Yeah, I thought so." Catra chuckles lightly, before taking Adora's hand, and it immediately rectifies the pale face problem. "It's are normally garbage anyway."

Catra leads them both around the store, amassing the components she needs for a D.I.Y, Adora's visibly overwhelmed but she settles when Catra promises she'll put it all together herself. She doesn't even blanch at how much of her time she's promising this woman over the next few weeks.

"What am I supposed to do with my old tank?" Adora asks, her arms overburdened with items as Catra passes them to her, considerate of the budget they'd agreed upon.

Catra pauses. "What do you—What?"

"Like, how do you dispose of a fish tank?"

Catra blinks. Once, twice. "Holy shit, don't get rid of it. Keep it. It's a perfectly good tank, you just need something smaller in it."

"But why would I want *two* tanks?"

"Why would you?" A *third* time. "I'm sorry, I'm gonna have to retract my previous agreement for dinner." She says it so deadpan

she knows Adora will recognise it as a joke.

"Pff ft, alright, how many do *you* have?" Adora reshuffles her armful, looking grateful that they're heading in the direction of the till now.

Catra's jaw locks a little in embarrassment, because if she hadn't come across as a hopeless nerd before...

"She has seven!" Scorpia answers for her.

Adora lets out a chortle of laughter but there's nothing unkind there at all. "Oh wow, seriously?"

"Some of them are small." She says in her defence. It comes out quiet, but Adora's smile remains bright so she doesn't feel the need to be bashful about it. Scorpia begins ringing up Adora's items, the tank itself has to be ordered in so won't arrive for a week or so but apart from that, Finn's all set.

"Maybe you can tell me about them at dinner?" Adora prompts. Catra searches her face to decipher if she's serious or just being polite. She finds no deceit there.

"Okay."

"Oh, I'm sure Wildcat would love to show off her collection, she's very proud of it." Scorpia scans the final item before listing off the total. Catra wants to kick her a little, she's trying to sound cool dude stop stifling that, but, uh, also...

"Wait," Catra says, glancing to make sure there will be no witnesses, she pulls out her employee discount card and runs it through. Micah lets them have a generous thirty per cent off and it more than pays back the fifty Adora had thrust in her direction earlier. "Ta-da."

Adora's expression is hard to read when she turns to her again, her payment card is paused mid-air on its way to the machine, but it's

kinda a mix of surprised, soft and grateful – it's a little intense actually. Awed, perhaps. "You won't get in trouble?"

"If I was gonna get in trouble here, it would have already happened." She says, leaning both of her forearms on the counter and cocking her hip a little.

"Yup! That's our Wildcat, troublemaker through and through. Sure keeps us on our toes!" Catra squints at her friend. *Jeez, Scorp, could you make me sound any more like a puppy that's going through a mouthing phase?*

Catra huffs heatlessly, straightening. "The boss is such a *dad*, he's basically a giant pushover." He's also the best manager Catra's ever had, but she's not gonna get sappy about that.

Something falters behind Adora's expression, but then she's slipping her card into the machine and tapping in the pin, so Catra excuses the expression as her recalling the number.

Half an hour after showing up, Adora's ready to leave again, Catra finds herself scrambling internally for an excuse to keep her in the shop a little bit longer. Adora's lunch break is over though so it'd be a pointless effort.

"See you later?"

"Yeah, see you later." Catra nods, her cheeks a tolerable shade of rosy.

She tries not to let a stupid smile bloom across her face like a weed (though a nice one, a dandelion maybe) when Adora waves to the fish in the koi pond that borders the path to the car park. She must fail, because Scorpia's suddenly sliding up toward her. Catra feels as though she's about to be lobotomized.

"You took a call out."

Catra swallows thickly. "Yeah, so what."

"You took a call out, insisted on nearly twice the usual fee, and then *didn't charge her.*" Scorpia lays the facts on the floor to dry out and shrivel in the sun as though it would make Catra confess to... something.

"Your point?"

"My *point* being that she's pretty cute. And dont think I didnt notice the pin on her jacket. When you said you were with a client last night I thought you meant in a stuffy office or dentist waiting room, not in a pretty sapphic's living room." Scorpia wiggles her eyebrows in jest.

"Okay," Catra scoffs, "First of all, it's not like I agreed to it knowing what she looked like, you cant tell how attractive someone is from just their voice over the phone. She sounded upset. Which is the only reason I agreed. And second." There actually isnt a second thing. "Shut up!" Catra finishes with instead, her cheeks feeling like hot coals.

"So, you think so too?"

One of Catra's eyebrows hikes toward her hairline.

"That she's cute." Scorpia clarifies, but the only reply she gets is Catra shoving roughly at her shoulder and a mumble that's probably still distinguishable as fuck off. It does nothing to unbalance her absolute *unit* of a friend. "I hope you have a nice date!" Scorpia calls out as Catra stomps towards the breakroom outback, letting the singularly raised middle finger of her left hand trail behind her.

Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The rain must have been holding off for the last twenty-four hours because it chooses that evening to downpour from the heavens as though it wasn't going to stop for forty days and forty nights. Catra didn't bring a raincoat. The road right outside Adora's place had been clogged with cars so she'd had to walk a fair distance while cursing at every footstep that soaked through her shoes. She finds herself standing at the front door and spamming the doorbell until she hears the scuffle of the lock being opened from the other side.

She's cold and sodden by the time she's in the hallway.

"Aw, have you started scuba diving? You know you're not supposed to wear normal people clothes while you're doing it, right?" Adora jests.

Catra scowls, water drips down her wrists onto the carpet, and from pretty much everywhere else too. "*Normal* people clothes?" Her glasses steam up as she speaks.

"Well, I mean, pretty sure anyone willing to go scuba diving in the actual ocean has to be a little bit batshit, you know?" Adora tuts. "There's a lot of weird stuff down there."

Catra thinks, *pathetic fallacy my ass.* If Adora's cheered up enough to be joking with her like this Catra assumes there's not gonna be any more tears this evening. She lets out a snort. "You know, I actually have been scuba diving. Multiple times," she says, while peeling off her jacket, as though it's supposed to throw a spanner in Adora's hypothesis.

"You think you're normal?" Adora outright coos, "Don't you have like, a gazillion fish tanks?"

Catra rolls her eyes, fighting an intractable smile, "Alright you ass, go fetch me a towel."

She's not sure how it happens (though twice isn't much of an untaintable track record) that these visits to Adora's keep bordering on a strange realm of not quite platonic.

She ends up in Adora's clothes. Fuck knows how that happens. Well, actually, Catra'd considered it for a whole five minutes while staring at the warm, dry set that Adora had laid out in offering, but just that time span was enough to set her shivering and peeling the rest of her garments off her skin.

Her teeth aren't chattering so loud when she finds Adora in the living room, a cup of hot coco in her hands, and fuck if Catra wouldn't kill for one of those right now—

Oh.

It actually *is* for her, Adora's handing it to her. "Um, thanks." Perfect warmth surrounds her palms as she accepts it, holding it close against her as she sips and feels it return life down to the frozen depths of her soul. "Holy fuck, that's good."

Adora lets out this little laugh in acknowledgement of the praise. "Thanks, it's, uh, grandma's recipe. Was, I guess."

Catra hums a sound that rivals the purr of a cat as she sinks down into the couch, feeling as toasty as a marshmallow in a hoodie that's two sizes too big on her.

Adora remains standing. There's not a lot of room unless they're fine with their thighs pressing up against each other, and it seems despite everything, Adora's trying to reinstate some sort of professionalism here. She sends a look toward the tank, Catra notices.

"I'll get to it, just.give me a minute." Another swig of hot chocolate, it's making her arms turn to noodles. "Did you do your homework?"

"Yeah!" Adora replies. "I watched all of them, and I think—I think I understand what I did wrong now," She wrings her hands like a schoolchild that's expecting a scolding. "I won't do it again."

"Okay."

"O.okay?" Adora frowns the slightest amount at the simplicity of her answer, Catra assumes. But can you blame her? She's just been given a drink that could lul a god to sleep.

"Yeah," She shrugs. "What else are you gonna do? We all make mistakes, we learn, and then we move on."

Adora protests. "But I almost *killed* him."

"Almost."

"But, I—" She stammers.

"You got help, didn't you? You noticed something was wrong, and you asked for help before it could get to that." Catra takes another sip, talking softer now. "Forgive yourself a little, will you?"

She feels Adora's weight as she settles down on the cushions beside her, slowly, like a mountain toppling over. Her gaze is a little bit distant now; Catra nudges her lightly with one elbow. "There isn't weed in this, is there?"

Adora blinks at her for a few seconds before her face cracks and she lets out a beautiful, snorty laugh.

Catra leaves the empty mug on the coffee table once she's finished. She feels rosy. The warmth of the drink had helped, but she's also spent the last five minutes beside Adora on a couch arguably too small for the both of them, so the flush in her cheeks is difficult to diagnose.

She steps toward the tank. Finn turns to look at her with his fins - (*you could have named him literally anything else*) - trailing behind in a dance of gold and white. He's more vibrant today, she notices, the water's still much clearer than yesterday, though she really wants to do something about those god-awful pink pebbles, and, huh...

"I think the whole thing's bullshit, and not that we should strictly adhere to these things anyway," Catra starts, tilting forward a little with her hands resting on her knees as she watches. "But are you aware your fish is technically female?"

She hears Adora stand, approach, behind her. "Seriously?"

"Yeah."

"Oh wow, Grandma always called him a boy. I just assumed she knew." Adora explains. "But, I mean...does it, um, does it really matter?"

"I mean, not really, I doubt Finn particularly cares. Pretty sure you have to have a decently advanced sense of self to have a gender identity, of which most animals are lacking." Catra shrugs.

"Huh," Adora says, mimicking Catra's posture. "You can't get trans animals?"

"I mean, you can get intersex animals, sure. But there's normally a distinct biological cause of that, genes, hormones, etc. So it gets kinda fuzzy when you start getting the concept of conscious spirit involved." Catra explains, turning to face her. "But what the fuck do we know, really?"

Adora turns to look at her with an expression Catra can't quite place, and she's pretty certain that her level of knowledge - or at least interest - in this field, might have just outed her a little. But she recalls Adora's pin and thinks, *now we're even at least.*

Catra straightens her spine then, "I should probably get to work."

"Right, me too" Adora follows. "Chinese?"

"Sounds fucking perfect."

The vials indicate the water's not so awful this time, it hasn't built up to flashing-red-warning-light levels over the last twenty-four hours so Catra's pretty certain Finn is past the worst of it.

"C'mere." She beacons to Adora who's been watching from the doorway since phoning the local delivery place. "It's your turn today, remember?"

The blonde's face has gone pale. "Um, I don't—" She begins to shake her head slightly, taking a step back like she's retreating. "Can't you just... do it for me?"

"Dude, you're gonna have to do this once a week for the rest of Finn's life, you gotta learn at some point." Adora lets out this tiny keening noise. Catra squares her shoulders but she's more amused than anything. "You really want to pay me fifty dollars a week for the

next five years?" That makes her step forward. "Good girl." Adora's face goes scarlet at that and it has Catra grinning devilishly.

"So," Catra settles back onto the couch half an hour later, picking at a cardboard container of noodles. She's using chopsticks, Adora opted for a fork. "Not so bad, huh?"

"No," Adora returns, her voice muffled through a mouthful of chicken. She blanches momentarily at how coarse she's being, but Catra just raises an eyebrow, amused. Adora swallows, coughing slightly. "I think I got it now, actually." It's cute that she seems proud of herself, though her forehead puzzles and Catra can only assume (although it might be hope) that it's over the realisation she's just admitted to not needing Catra's help anymore. "But won't I have to do it all over again with the new tank when it arrives?"

"Nah," Catra says, rearranges her legs to be crisscrossed, one knee leans against the arm of the couch and the other leans right onto Adora's thigh. Catra notices the blonde's ribcage still as though breathing might make her choke. Catra smiles into her noodles. "You just have to move the whole filter over and it will be fine."

"Oh," Adora says softly.

There's a few minutes of eating in silence before anyone speaks again, but Catra's starting to melt back into the cushions with a belly full of carbs so it's hard to recollect what the time frame is, precisely.

"Hey, I wanted to ask..." Adora starts, with an air of casualness that she can't detect if it's faux or not, and it makes Catra's heart immediately *stop.* "Your manager, um, the dad one-" *Okay, not what I was expecting but alright,* her heart begins again. "He's not called Micah, by any chance, is he?"

Catra blinks at her. "Uh, yeah," her head nods stiffly in puzzlement. "That's him."

"Oh wow. I thought afterwards, how many aquatic stores can there possibly be in one town? You know? But I'd only just moved back here and she'd never told me the name of it and I think I just called up in such a panic the first local number google offered me, it didn't even click. But what a small world, huh? And kinda freaky that maybe we would have ended up meeting under different circumstances anyway, like it could have been fate-" her face paints itself pink. "Pfft, not that, um, I think that we were *supposed* to meet or anything it's just that isn't life weird like that sometimes, how people can"—

"Adora."

"Yeah?" it comes out squeaky.

"Backtrack a little for me, maybe?"

"Right." Adora lets out an exhale that must have been building while she rambled. "I'm friends with Glimmer, or was, childhood friends I guess, but we're spending time together again now I'm back."

Catra's whole face grimaces involuntarily. She uses another mouthful of noodles to try to quell the irritation it sparks within her ribcage; it's not made much of a difference by the time she swallows. "Glimmer goddamn Brightmoon, I can't believe you know that bitch."

Adora goes slack-jawed. "She's not that bad."

"She's nothing but a prissy little rich girl." Catra squints as though the woman in question were standing right before her and her own eyes had learned to inflict wounds. "Her dad once let her re-scape one of our display tanks, she chose the one in particular that *I'd* designed and been working on for a *whole year.* She ripped everything out and turned the whole thing pink!"

Adora chortles, her cheeks flushed. But then she suddenly pales, her eyes flicker towards her own tank, but it's not the type of embarrassment Catra would expect had Adora adopted the insult as meant for her too.

Catra's eyes follow toward Finn's nauseating, fuschia smothered home. "You didn't."

"—Adora flounders. "Her dad owns an aquatic store, I thought she knew what she was doing!"

"That tank is an abomination, Adora." Catra retorts, but she's certain there's still humour woven into her voice.

"I know ," she replies a bit pitifully . And then, "I'd love it if you'd design Finn's new one."

Catra pauses, settles back into the cushions. "You haven't even seen any of my designs."

Adora spins in her seat, facing Catra now with a dorky smile on her face, her elbow propped up against the backrest and her chin leaning into her hand. "Then show me."

"You serious?"

"Of course," Adora pouts. "You have photos on your phone?"

Yeah, too fucking many, probably. Catra retrieves the device from the front pouch pocket of her hoodie, Adora's hoodie, she reminds herself, then taps open the album before tilting her screen toward Adora. The thumb of her free hand starts playing with the hem of her sleeve, but the thought that the material's *so soft* there that she'd happily steal the hoodie from Adora isn't helping.

Catra clears her throat. "I guess start with the smallest?" Adora doesn't protest to that, and her face seems genuinely engaged, so Catra begins. She skims through. It's not as thorough as she'd like to

be, because try as she might, she doesn't want to dull Adora if she's just sitting through this to be polite. The first three are pretty uniform. Cube shape tanks, thematically all similar in design as well as size, aligned on the same cabinet and thriving with bright, lush greens.

Adora's eyes go wide. "Oh wow. They're so pretty, are those real plants?"

"Duh," She tolerates Adora taking the phone from her hand to look a little closer. Catra watches, unfazed, as she slides through the album (there's literally only fish and aquascapes here so there's nothing potentially mortifying to stumble across.) The next few are snaps of the actual fish living in them. Three bettas. All halfmoons, because if you're gonna get fighting fish, why wouldn't you go all out? One's yellow and white (though it's a shade closer to gold). The second's a red and black koi, and the third is completely, stunningly, blue.

"Do they have names?" Adora asks innocently.

"Uh, no," Catra shakes her head. "I have, like, a lot, it would be hard to keep track."

The woman beside her just keeps browsing, moving through the larger community setups she has and occasionally muttering more 'oh wow's under her breath.

Catra mostly designs her tanks for herself. She's entered a few online aquascape competitions before, won a few even, but she's never felt so thoroughly inspected until now.

Adora stops. She's reached the larger of Catra's marine tanks and allows herself a few seconds to take it all in. "Holy shit."

"Y up," She drums her hands lightly against her leg a few times. It had taken four years, nearly all of her disposable income, and a few rehabilitated adoption cases from work, but it was, shell admit, a masterpiece.

"Could you make mine look like that?" Adora turns to her with sparkles in her eyes like gemstones.

"Uh, no." Catra replies bluntly , her forehead scrunching a little.

"Why not?" Adora pouts.

"You ever seen a happy goldfish in the *ocean*?" She cocks an eyebrow. Adora visibly registers her mistake, making an 'oh' motion with her mouth. "You're pretty limited with what you can do with a goldfish tank, they're pigs and like to tear plants up." She stretches her arms out in front of her to crack her knuckles. "But I'll see what I can do."

Adora taps through to one last photo. A scrawny black cat stares past its own reflection to a pair of clownfish sat within the tendrils of a pink anemone. "Aww, you have a cat?"

"Yeah, um," Catra nods. "That's Melog."

Her heart rate picks up minutely when Adora closes the album and, evidently, starts searching for more photos of the cat. And like, it's not that she *has* anything embarrassing saved for sure, she also hasn't exactly checked in a while and she'd rather not have someone poking around of their own accord. She takes the phone back.

"Sorry ," Adora responds immediately , but Catra sends her a smile she hopes is both an apology and forgiveness.

"Here," She finds others. One of Melog curled up like a swaddled baby in Scorpia's arms, it's a little blurry from the rush of trying to get a photo before he'd start wriggling. Adora smiles. It fades by a fraction before she's withdrawing a little, the warmth of her body pulling away as she tries to reinstate some space between them on the couch. They'd gotten pretty close and cozy , Catra's just realising. The withdrawal is a bit of a bitch, she instantly feels cold again down one side of her body. Catra swallows. "Everything okay?"

"Yeah," Adora's having trouble meeting her eyes. "Your, um, flatmate seems really nice. You must be pretty close living together *and* working together."

Oh.

Oh.

"Scorpia's pretty chill. She spends a lot of time at her girlfriend's house though so it's not like we're stuck at the hip. I think we'd get a bit pissy with each other if we were."

Adora inhales and it's like a balloon being inflated but she's just filled with joy instead, she might as well have breathed in a ton of helium too because her voice is a little squeaky when she breathes out, "Oh, cool. That's, um, cool. Coolio, awesome."

What was it about queer people stumbling around in herds?

"Yeah," Catra replies simply, slipping her phone back into the pocket of a hoodie that does not belong to her. "So, you want me out of these clothes or what?"

Adora chokes out a, "Wh-what?"

"Your clothes," Catra states plainly so she won't lose her again. "Do you want them back *now*, or...?"

"Oh!" Adora shakes her head, her cheeks flushed. "No, keep them, it's alright. You can just wash them and return them next time." *Next time?* She'd said it was such assurance Catra's wondering if she's forgotten about prior arranged plans. "I'm sure I can do without for a few days." Her eyes scan over Catra's outfit then, Catra's not sure if she's being deceived by the way the blue of her irises seem to give way to black just a fraction.

Her throat feels thick when Catra says, "Okay."

"Okay ," Adora parrots back, though she' s suddenly struggling to make eye contact again.

Catra runs the palm of her hands down the material covering her things, clearing her throat. "I should probably head back."

"Right," Adora nods, *jumps up* . "I'll walk you to the door."

Catra rises more slowly. "You don't have to do that, I know where the door is, it's not exactly a big apartment." But damn it, now that cute pout is back. "And they say chivalry is dead, come on then dummy ," Catra nods her head towards the entryway. "You can be a gentleman for me if you want to be," Adora' s face goes pink again, Catra can't help but preen about that.

They both pause by the entryway, Catra tilts herself back against the wall to give herself a little bit of breathing room. "Thanks for dinner ."

Adora beams. "Thanks for saving my fish."

"It was nothing," she says, folding her arms — surrounded now in the soft, cotton hug of Adora's clothes. "And as much as I enjoyed being Finn's hero, I'd rather not be needed again anytime soon."

Adora nods, before she's shuffling on her feet. "I'll make sure to take you out properly next time."

Catra freezes like a record scratch. "What?"

"What?" Adora follows suit.

"Take me." Catra' s voice fades out. "I'm sorry , was this supposed to be a *date*?"

Adora blinks a few times, then, "Um. I, uh," a few more, her whole face a rose blush, "...no? It' s a *question* , the dumbass. I mean, you agreed to dinner, and Glimmer — Glimmer said you don't normally go out to clients like this, I thought" —

"Oh, *Glimmer* said?" Catra's eyebrow skyrockets. She doesn't intend it to be harsh but the bitterness is still lurking from earlier. Adora retreats immediately but her feet stay cemented to the same floor her eyes are now stuck on. "Hey," Catra returns, soft as the rain is now on the opposite side of the door. Then she steps forward, raises onto her tiptoes, and presses a kiss against Adora's cheek in lieu of her own apology. Adora's eyes meet hers, holding a glint like something shiny at the bottom of the ocean, as Catra pulls away again. "Your friend is a nosy little gremlin," She lets out a huff. "But she's also not lying to you."

"Oh." Adora lets out an awestruck breath. "So I can see you again?"

Catra rolls her eyes playfully. "Finn's new tank arrives on Friday, you think you can wait that long?"

Adora swallows and it looks like the honest answer's gonna be 'probably not,' but she replies with a steely nod instead.

The rain is lighter as Catra walks towards her car this time, but she finds it's not as cold when she's grinning up at the evening sky.

Chapter End Notes

> Sorry for disappearing for a while there, life problems, what can you do. My muse has been unreliable the last few months because my living situation is not great and being a sapphic enby while living with a parent who watches Ben Shapiro videos on our living room tv has been 🙃 fun 🙃

Chapter 3

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora keeps sending her videos of Finn.

She doesn't message exactly , Catra's not sure if she's just not a chatty person through phone screens or if she's still walking unknown ground and keeping to safe ones.

It starts the next morning, the shop's quiet so Catra pulls the device out to browse when she has a dull few minutes sat behind the tills. The notification, and Adora's name beside it, instantly makes her chest feel, disgustingly, like it's been filled with sunshine. She opens it to find the goldfish looking content in their sickeningly pink tank, and Adora's beaming face just about visible in the reflection of the glass.

Do you not have a job, you dork. Catra sends back.

I work from home. Followed by another picture, though this one shows off their tail fins nicely and she can appreciate for a second why some people like goldfish.

Adora is quiet for the rest of the day, until Catra's finishing up dinner and her phone chimes with another ~~m~~ore of the same. She snaps back a picture of Melog curled up in a ball on the couch when she sits to eat. They don't have a dining table. There's not really space amongst her seven tanks in the flat, though the three smallest are in her bedroom.

Adora simply types: *cute.* And that's that.

It continues that way till Friday, Adora sends her another photo mid-way through the afternoon but this time it's of an empty, brand-new

tank sat dead center in her living room with the caption *help!* Catra drums her fingernails against the table in the staff room where she's sat, excitement zipping through her veins by the prospect of a blank canvas and the plentiful hardscape the store sells to choose from.

What's your budget for decor? She asks, her heart beating a little bit faster than before, and yeah, alright, maybe she is a nerd, she can accept that ~~-b~~ut she's already brainstorming and pulling out a sketchpad.

Catra arrives at Adora's with her arms full of rocks and driftwood and her eyes as bright as Polaris. "Okay , so I had some ideas I want to run by you before I get started,"she says as she passes Adora in the entryway without even saying hello. "I got two dif ferent types of wood to see what you preferred but the Redmoor is particularly stunning so I think you should go with that, and it will really add a nice amount of height to the layout."She kneels, beginning to place each piece carefully on the coffee table as though they were gems and not, well, *rocks*. "I got you sand for the substrate, it's quite a dark colour but it looks much more natural and it won't show up the mess as easily. And this,"she indicates toward the rock, "is Seiryu stone. I thought we could go with a staggered theme of rock reaching up from the bottom and then have the roots like this-"~~-s~~he picks the branches up and arranges them reaching downward-~~-s~~o that it almost looks like mangrove roots, and we can attach it onto the top somehow and have it spreading down. I think I want it all to the right-hand side of the tank, then Finn still has plenty of open space to swim on one side and lots of toys on the other."She claps her hands down onto her knees. "What do you think?"She finally turns to face Adora.

Adora's eyes remind her of an apple and cinnamon pie in autumn. Sweet and warm that it makes her melt a little from the inside out. "I

think it's really cute that you're so passionate about this."

Catra scoffs. She can feel her cheeks dust with pink as she starts to arrange the layout of the rocks over the table.

Scorpia had paled when Catra'd declared at the end of the workday that she was gonna buy some stuff. "Please, no more." She'd *begged*. Catra had simply rolled her eyes and explained it was for Adora, but then her friend had started badgering her for an entirely different reason.

Anyway.

The new tank is sitting in the middle of the room right now and Catra's pretty sure that's not where it's staying forever. "Where is this going?"

"Oh, um, I wanted it up against the wall there," Adora gestures sheepishly. "But the delivery people kinda just dumped it and left."

"I'm sure we can manage," Catra decides, sending a smirk Adora's way. "You feeling strong?"

She flexes one arm and Catra might laugh at the gesture and how playful the blonde's expression is if the sight didn't make her mouth suddenly dry. She clears her throat. "Good. Let's get having time buddy."

There's a little bit of swearing and multiple hisses of '*careful!*' but they managed to move it over. Catra honestly doesn't put as much oomph in as she could have, but manual labor, ya know? Doctors orders. Plus, watching Adora's arms work is a *treat* for sapphics everywhere.

Finn's original tank hadn't been positioned with any real rhyme or reason, so putting the new one right beside it actually evens out the room a bit better, Catra thinks. There's a small gap between the two. A plant would be nice, maybe a parlour palm or something tall.

She realises she's been observing with her hands on her hips and her head tilted when Adora asks, "What now?" And she feels her body straighten.

"Now's the fun part," Catra grins devilishly before pulling up her sleeves.

It takes her over an hour to get everything positioned *just so*. Sand rinsed, stones in place, and the driftwood branches arranged to hang down from the top near the back, and slightly to the left – the longest reaching like sunbeams in all directions. Followed by the agonisingly slow process of filling it back up with water. It's not the most stunning thing she's ever designed. The greenery is lacking. But Adora's got a swimming lawnmower called Finn, so, itll do.

"Tada," She gestures with jazz hands towards the tank, but it might be anticlimactic since Adora's been watching from the couch this whole time and the last twenty minutes were mostly Catra being pedantic about minor edits.

Adora's smiling at her anyway. "It looks amazing, wow, thank you."

"Better than pure pink, huh Finn?" She twists a little toward the fish that's been largely unaware of the addition to Adora's living room, and what's about to become their whole world.

"Do you think I could put fake plants in? Since he'd destroy real ones?"

Catra's nose scrunches. "I mean, you can do what you want, but fake stuff looks even tackier in a natural theme." She turns to Adora. "You're welcome to try real plants, but they're kinda expensive if they're just gonna get eaten all the time."

"Right. I think it's nice like this too."

Adora moves to stand right beside her as they observe the two tanks. She's pretty close actually, and when Catra moves to fold her arms, the back of her hand brushes over the skin of Adora's. Catra swallows thickly.

Adora doesnt seem to have registered the touch. "So now we move Finn across?"

"Y up."

"And you're sure it won't cause problems again?" She sounds genuinely worried.

Catra replies, her tone soft. "I've done this a bunch of times, Adora. Finn will be fine. We just have to keep an eye on the water quality for the next few days as the ecosystem adjusts. I'll walk you through each step as I'm doing it and hopefully it will all make a bit more sense."

Adora replies, still sounding a little lost. "Did you learn all this at college?"

Catra pauses, her forehead creasing. "No, actually . I picked this all up from keeping fish myself," She bumps her hip into Adora's lightly then. "Y ou don't need a bachelor's degree in marine biology to be able to understand all this."

Adora smiles at her gratefully, hooking into the topic, she asks. "Where'd you go?"

It catches Catra off guard as she plans in her head what the next step is for Finn's relocation. His old tank has been half drained into the new, moving across the filter now makes sense. "Hmm?"

"College?" Adora' s head tilts cutely like a puppy observing something fascinating.

Catra's cheeks tint at the attention and she immediately tries to redirect it, busying her hands with sorting out the tanks. "Oh, Brightmoon, you?"

Adora just shakes her head.

"Not Brightmoon, or...not at all?"

"I couldn't really afford to," She shrugs heavily. "I, uh, I was in the foster system for a lot of my childhood. I stayed with my grandma for a few years but then her memory started to get a bit fuzzy and they decided she wasn't fit to care for me anymore, so"…

Catra's heart drops within her sternum like dead weight. "Oh jeez, that sucks."

Adora lets out a deep-chested sigh. "Yeah."

"But uh, me too, about the foster kid thing," Catra says, her eyes flitting back to Adora's as she positions the filter in the new aquarium, she'll attach the new one that she'd bought with Adora too, but having both going will only help the water quality.

One of Adora's eyebrows rises the tiniest fraction, her expression unraveling like a rose to something soft and tender underneath. "Really?"

"Yeah," Catra replies, her throat catching slightly. "I got into college on scholarship, spending all my evenings at the library was one of the few things Weaver let me do outside of the house—I was banned from team sports because of my, uh..." She clears her throat as though that's gonna cover up the candid slipup there. "But I took every chance I could get to delay going back to that witch's home in the evenings. I guess the study hours added up over the years, huh?"

Adora hums softly, it's a grief-stricken sound, but in a way that it feels *shared* for once. "Can I ask how you ended up there?" A tentative

question as she stares toward the ground. "It was a car accident for me. Both parents, and a twin brother, actually." Her voice quietens then, "he was only three."

"Fuck."

Adora's voice is thick. "Yup."

Catra dwells over that for a drawn-out minute before she decides to dive in headfirst and spill her soul out too, might as well. "I was abandoned, apparently. Im not sure how much of it is true because Weaver liked to really dig the knife in about it, but I was released to the state when I was less than twenty-four hours old, so..."

"You werent adopted?" Adora's eyebrows scrunch. Catra understands the confusion because most adoption agencies would have snapped up a fresh-out-the womb kid as though they were made of pure gold.

Catra goes quiet for a moment. "No, I, um... Medical shit." Her hand drifts to hover over her chest for a second, absently. "I guess I was a pity case that was never actually quite pitiful enough."

"Fuck."

Catra lets out a laboured laugh. "Yeah," She notices Adora observing her for a few seconds and it makes her feet shuffle over the carpet. "It was a heart thing, if you're wondering. Three different surgeries before turning five years old is kinda a downer for prospective parents." She clears her throat, her expression turning toward a smirk again. "Dont ask me to show you the scar though."

Adora returns the smile but there's evidence of water in her eyes this time, regardless, the room feels lighter again.

It takes them an hour and a half to acclimatise Finn, which, frankly, Catra thinks is excessive given the preparation she's already put in place. But Adora had been really nervous about it. Like, hands visibly trembling nervous.

Anyway, Catra's not going to complain about getting to spend more time with Adora in her cozy apartment.

Food appears at some point. Adora announces she's going to make them dinner and then vanishes for forty minutes into the kitchen. The scent in the apartment changes until it's making Catra's mouth water – she'd assumed at first it would be a relatively simple dish, they are both twenty-somethings after all. Then Adora materialises with two plates of homemade Salmon risotto and appears to entirely miss the way Catra's jaw drops a few inches.

"You can cook?"

Adora's attention flickers towards her as she settles on the opposite end of the couch. "Um, yeah."

"Like, you deadass just went and made this from scratch?"

"Yes," Adora frowns. "Is there something wrong with it?"

"No," Catra returns quickly. "No, nothing's wrong, it's perfect, thank you." She supposes that's what happens when you spend a large chunk of your childhood living with your grandma rather than terrified of being yelled at for taking one step into the kitchen. "Thank you." She's not sure why she says it again, only that it's been an age since she had a warm, lovingly made meal like this. Scorpia bakes, sure, but this feels different somehow.

Adora settles deeper into the cushions beside her. Their backs are up against opposite armrests so they can face each other, legs entangled a little.

"So Finn' s all good now?" Adora pipes up after a while.

"Y eah, they should be all set. Ill swing by tomorrow to do another check but that should only take ten minutes."

"Oh," Adora pauses then. "Y ou- um... Right."

Catra narrows her eyes in the blonde's direction, but Adora's staring down at her dinner. "What?"

"No, I was just—" She witnesses Adora' s throat bob a few times. "I dont really have an excuse to have you over here anymore, huh?"

Catra pauses. "Y ou dont need an *excuse* Adora, though Im sure youll come up with one." She teases. "Y ou've got a whole other tank that's completely empty if you want me to do something with it."

"I've been thinking of selling it actually . I really dont need two." Adora says before taking a big bite off her fork.

Catra manages to restrain herself for a whole five seconds, which she's pretty proud of actually. "Can I have it?"

Adora swallows, one eyebrow raised. "Really?"

"Y eah." She says decisively before she can rationalise this might not be the healthiest decision. "Dont judge me."

Adora raises her hands up in surrender. "Dont you think eight is a bit too—"

"No. Actually , I think it's the perfect amount. I have space left in my bedroom."

Adora's expression cracks into a smile. "W ell, in that case, of course you can have it."

Catra grins toward her dinner plate, Scorpia's going to fucking kill her.

"So you're really into this stuff, huh?"

Catra scoffs and then it turns into a laugh completely of its own accord. "Sure seems so."

"Would you want to do it, like, professionally?"

Catra meets her eyes and holds her there. "I mean, yeah, that would be fucking dope, but there's not really a huge market for it," She takes another bite of her salmon and rice. "Micah lets me advertise my name and contact details behind the tanks I set up, and I've done this sort of stuff—" She waves a hand towards Finn's aquarium. "—For friends as favours. But I have no goddamn clue how to make a living out of it."

Adora's face turns fond. "So you've thought about it a lot?"

"A heck of a lot," Catra nods slowly. "As nice as Micah is, I don't really want to be stuck in retail forever, but it's nice to have found something that at least *feels* like it makes my degree relevant to what I'm doing. Even if it is still minimum wage."

Adora looks aghast. "You only get minimum wage?"

"Yeah. But we get so much free stuff it kinda cancels out. Lots of work perks."

Adora's face scrunches even further.

"What?" Catra prompts.

"I'm gonna speak to Glimmer. You should be earning more., I cant believe that."

Catra's eyes roll. "Okay, calm down. There's really no need to be getting her involved, god, do you have any idea how awkward that would be?"

"But—"

"Adora." She scolds. "It's an unskilled position, technically—"

"Unskilled my ass. You went to college, and you're obviously super-duper smart, I can't grasp how you could possibly be earning less than I am."

"Alright hotshot, what do *you* do?"

Adora stammers for a moment. "I work in marketing for a company that produces kid's action figures."

"Sexy, alright, and how long have you been in that job?"

"Five years."

"Well, I've not even been in the full-time workforce for a whole year yet. So can you please chill out? My career is doing fine."

"Still, I thought better of Micah."

"It's a hobby shop, it doesn't earn him a lot of money."

"Then that's not a functional business model!"

"Adora."

"What?" She looks like she's ready to go to battle for her, it's pretty cute, actually.

"I could earn more if I wanted to. We're allowed to take on call-outs whenever we want. Micah hooks us up with maintenance gigs and lets us off work early to fulfill them while still getting a full day's pay on top. And the health insurance is top fucking notch, so..."

"Oh."

"Your dedication to this is super hot, but I'm not ready to handle being a waiting war wife," She says dramatically, placing a hand over her chest. "It would be super bad for my heart."

"Wife?" Adora beams warmly at her and it lights the coals inside Catra's abdomen till she feels as though she's sat right next to a hearth fire.

"Fuck, of, it was a metaphor ." She returns her attention to her food so she can finish it before it goes cold.

"Mmhmm,"

A few minutes pass before Adora clears her throat. "I didn't pay you last time." She realises.

"No. I wasn't expecting you to, you bought us food, dude."

Adora's fork skills as it picks at her plate. "Okay , so... are we hanging out, or are you here to do a job?"

Catra nudges her knee into Adora's. "We're hanging out, doofus."

"So... would you maybe want to hang out somewhere that—uh, isn't my living room?" *Your bedroom?* Catra thinks, but she lets Adora continue. "Maybe a movie, or a picnic, or we could go for a walk along the beach, or dinner"—

Catra interrupts. "You ever been to Brightmoon Bay Aquarium?"

Adora stares at her, before her face cracks incredulously. "You're serious?"

"What, you don't think aquariums are good date material?"

"So it would be? An actual date, I mean."

Catra rolls her eyes. "Haven't we already had, like, two of those now?"

Adora's face pales. "You said it wasn't!"

Catra snorts and then starts cackling. "Well, if we've had two 'debatable' dates, that has to be a whole ass date combined, right?"

Adora blinks at her.

She rests her head on her fist, propped up against the back of the couch. "Sweatheart, all I'm saying is that you shouldn't be flustered to ask me out at this point."

"I don't want to cross a line." She explains.

Catra gestures towards their legs that are practically draping over one another, "Please cross some lines, I'm actively asking you to."

Adora looks troubled then. "It's just—I assumed wrong...last time. I don't want to do that again."

"Adora, if you don't ask me out then I'm gonna ask *you* out, I'm only waiting because you seem so dang sure you want to be the one to do it."

"Okay," Adora takes a deep breath. "Catra, do you want to go on a date with me?"

"Yes, absolutely. Glad we've straightened that out. So, aquarium, or?..."

Adora lets out a snort as her face breaks into a smile like sunshine behind clouds. "Yeah, I would love to go to an aquarium with you. I'd love to witness you in full-on geek mode."

Catra braces a hand against her chest dramatically. "I am offended if you think it gets worse than this."

"I am *looking forward* to it getting worse than this." Adora counters, nudging Catra's thigh with her foot. "Eat up though, can't have you going home hungry again."

They pencil in the date for Sunday. Two days away, which would normally rattle Catra's nerves but for some reason, the butterflies that Adora fills her stomach with dont ache like she' s familiar with. The flittering is gentle and soft, and kinda warm. Spreading through her body like a rainbow (which, super-duper gay, by the way), and leaving her smiling like an idiot all through Saturday too. Scorpia notices, naturally.

Catra visits, as promised, to check on Finn and do some minor maintenance. A professional visit would have taken maybe thirty minutes but she stays for three hours and only leaves when she realises she has to go home to feed Melog and sort out her own tanks for the week.

And yeah, if she's seeing Adora every day for three days straight, so what?

It's quiet when they arrive. It's a beautifully sunny day so anyone heading this direction seems to be going toward the beach. Most of the aquarium is dark and indoors, so it makes sense. Adora's glad for the privacy though.

"Will you let me pay?" Adora asks as they approach the ticket of fice.

Catra sends her an affectionate look. "Uh, sure. Ill let you pay whatever they wanna charge us."

Adora frowns at the way she phrased that and it's not till Catra flashes a blue and green card with a whale on the center toward the

admissions clerk that Adora realises. Deadpan, she says, "You have a season pass."

"Yup."

The clerk asks, "Would you like to make a donation on top of your ticket purchase today?"

"Yeah, okay," Adora answers once she's over the bemusement. "Five dollars?"

"That'll be five dollars then please."

It returns tenfold, and Adora pivots to blink at Catra.

"What?" She shrugs. "I get a free guest once a month. And Scorpia's pretty bored of this place by now."

"How much did that thing cost you?"

"Eighty-nine dollars," Catra answers. "It's the best purchase I've ever made."

Adora pays the donation in cash and then they're walking under the archway, into the dark corridor. The hum of filters behind the thick walls is noticeable immediately, though it sounds like they've stepped onto a submarine where everything is watery and mellowed. Surrounded by white noise that simultaneously makes her want to fall asleep and go wild swimming, Adora can appreciate the tranquility of this place.

It's mostly just factoids on the walls for the first few steps, and then a small hole in the wall reveals glass and water and blue illuminating light. Catra leads them toward it.

"Where did this all start? This fascination with aquatic life?" Adora asks Catra, debating whether or not she's brave enough to reach out for the other girl's hand while they're stationary.

Catra's already devoutly watching, it's got seahorses in, Adora notices, but she mostly looking at the brunette and how her eyes have lit up under the glow of the marine lights and her own excitement. "My social worker took me to an aquarium once before dropping me off at the foster home I was in prior to Weaver's. I think I was about four years old at the time. Not sure it was even legal, but I guess we had a few hours to kill before arriving at the new place." Catra pauses, and then. "There's not a whole lot of good memories from my childhood. I guess it just stuck out."

It goes quiet then, Adora watches Catra in the simplicity of observing the little reef before them before she straightens and surprises at the dedication in Adora's gaze. "Having fun?" She raises an eyebrow, a smirk beginning to break through.

"Yeah," Adora replies, a little bit breathily. "It's really pretty here."

Catra's face flushes though her expression doesn't falter, maybe she assumes the tint in her cheeks is less obvious in the dim light. "Come on," Adora feels a hand slide into hers. "You haven't seen anything yet."

Words start coming out of Catra's mouth, species names and the occasional latin, but Adora's mostly just following as her date (her *date*, wow) points and rambles energetically.

The first larger tank they come across houses an octopus, Adora can't remember what kind because Catra suddenly refers to it by a *pet* name and it's the only thing Adora's mind holds onto.

"How on earth do you know it's called Double Trouble?"

"I come here multiple times a month, Adora. They do scheduled feeding and talks, their handler, Connie, recognises me on sight by now."

"Fish have handlers?"

"Double T rouble does, hence the name – they're a handful," Catra explains. "Did you know they're as smart as most three-year-olds? And just as capable of getting into mischief."

"I did not," Adora replies.

"And they're a type of mollusc, so what you're looking at is basically if a snail learned to swim and got super brainy at the same time."

"Uh-huh," Adora's knowledge of marine life is severely lacking, apparently. Doesn't matter though because Catra's got her enraptured. "You ever thought about working somewhere like this?"

Catra nods slowly. "I *thought* about it, sure, but most of the work here is in the husbandry, and I would rather get into the creative side of things. Being able to design one of these giant scapes would be rad though." She admits, just as they step under an archway and the ceiling above their head opens up to a glass tunnel. A turtle swims directly over them. Adora cranes her neck so far to watch it that she almost trips over her own toes.

Catra's beaming at her with blue light flickering over her face in patterns of the water above them when Adora looks back down, she must have gotten lost in the sight of it all for a hot minute there. Catra seems pleased she's enjoying herself.

"I have more experience designing freshwater though, so maybe I shouldn't be let loose on one of the city's main tourist attractions just yet."

"I think you'd do an amazing job," Adora says, and then adds. "I'd love to see your tanks in person, they're probably a sight to behold."

Catra's cheeks turn rosey again. "They're not quite as spectacular as this," Catra admits, glancing up through the depths of water over their heads and the colour and life within it.

Catra's hand is still in hers, the skin is soft there and it's like carrying around her own personal pocket heater, but, and this is the best part, it's also attached to *Catra.*

"Maybe not, but, they'd be yours," Adora says, following Catra's gaze upward. She swears she witnesses Catra's throat bob in the corner of her eye. Then the shorter girl kinda rocks on her feet like she's hesitating, before she nudges them toward a fork in the tunnel, into the nook of a dead end and the access door that leads beyond. It's darker here.

"We're not about to break in are we?"

"No, you dork, there's nothing interesting to see back there anyway," Catra says before spinning around to face her again.

Another raised eyebrow.

"Eh, perks of being a regular." Catra leans back against the wall there, inviting Adora within her space a step by tugging lightly on her hand.

"Hey," Adora says, flustered.

"Hey," Catra returns, they're practically nose to nose. There's no one around right now to see but if an employee opens the door suddenly to their right they could be in trouble.

Nobody does.

Catra waits, breathing stilled, her lips parted slightly as her eyes flicker down to Adora's. She's aware then how purposefully Catra has positioned herself, positioned *them,* and she knows Catra's

asking for something that's got Adora's brain stammering out an 'oh, wow'.

Adora leans forward slowly, just to be safe, "Um, can I?—

"Yes."

The kiss is like warm honey and Adora can feel it soothing through every fiber of her being, flesh and soul, as she presses Catra back up against the wall. Catra makes a soft sound, sighing maybe, or a quiet moan —likely both. Adora finds one of her own hands moving to stream through the hair at the back of Catra's neck, her thumb ghosting over Catra's jawline. Her other hand's moved down to Catra's waistline and is holding her there. Catra's have bunched into the material of the sweater sat directly over Adora's chest, tugging her further forward despite the lack of room left between them. She feels as though she's floating, held weightless underwater, and the sounds that escape Catra are something straight from scripture they're so divine.

It might be the longest first kiss Adora's ever had with someone. The best. The best too, absolutely the b—

The door beside them suddenly creaks. Catra moves like a dart to duck under Adora's arm and tug them back through the exhibit, giggling, giddy and red-faced as she does. Adora's pretty sure her's has gone crimson too, but in the best possible way.

Catra sits contently in the passenger side of Adora's car as she drives her home, a dolphin plushy in her arms bigger than Melog that Adora bought her from the gift shop. It's quiet as they drive. Catra still feels like she's halfway up into the atmosphere after everything,

and it takes the car slowing down to a stop outside her own ground-floor apartment for Catra to drift back to earth.

They'd gotten dinner on the way back, fast food burgers aren't exactly romantic but they'd unanimously agreed on the choice. Adora parked up the car overlooking the bay and they'd eaten watching the sun dip below the horizon of a spectacularly pink ocean. So, it made up for it, she thinks.

Catra clicks the car door open on her side, but doesn't yet push it open to leave.

"I'll see you tomorrow?" Adora inquires.

"Yeah," Catra smiles, it might be a little bit goofily, "I'll see you tomorrow."

"Cool," Adora beams. "Awesome. I'm sure Finn's looking forward to seeing you too!"

Catra steps out of the car, ducking down to finish the conversation now she's stood on the curb. "Goodbye Adora, and thanks-" she lifts the dolphin that's tucked under one arm. "-for this. It's very sweet."

"You're very sweet," Adora returns.

She feels her cheeks heat and rolls her eyes. "Shut up. Go home already." She thunks the door finally, but Adora just rolls down the window.

"Aw, you'll miss me when I'm gone." *Yeah probably.* "Goodnight, Cat."

"Goodnight, Adora." She waves as she watches Adora pull away and head down the road.

She stays out there for a little while even after the car's no longer in sight, and if she struggles to fall asleep because she can't stop smiling, then who else but the ceiling has to know?

Chapter End Notes

Writing has been hard but I'm doing a babified version of NaNoWriMo and pacing myself, this is the result, enjoy x

Chapter 4

Chapter Notes

is this what i planned when I first started this fic? no, lmao

Mondays are Mondays, and the start to the next week is nothing out of the ordinary, remarkable or significant in any god damn way. Catra's not sure what she expected. But after the weekend she's had it feels like the wake from the advancement in her love life that's got serotonin buzzing through her veins should have spread through the whole planet, she's experiencing it so intensely.

As it is, Kyle greets her with his usual, stiff smile and gangly limbs that she swears one day will end up knocking over a whole display. It's just the two of them for the first hour. She's so fucking jittery from excitement she almost wants to ask him how his weekend went just so she can have the question ricocheted and actually be able to release the pressure in her chest from it all.

And like, she doesn't *mind* Kyle. He keeps to himself, and, consequently, out of her way. The far end of the shop, often. But it works and they've got an understanding going on — he's learned what every one of her glares mean by now and she's accepted that, for a runt, he does know what the hell he's doing. They're not friends, but she might, when pressed, admit that she's come to tolerate him. So what the hell's got her like this that she suddenly wants to bother him with the news of her weekend?

They begin the round of morning chores. There are thousands of mouths to feed in the sale and display tanks and Micah likes the glass to look pristine, so she sets to work before the customers are due to arrive. It distracts her for the first few hours.

Their manager arrives just after half nine and disappears into his office. He's often late but she can't really blame him because there's

not a lot he can get done in the first hour of opening that can't also be done any other hour of the day (perks of owning your own business, huh). He stays late too, most nights. Tucks the fish into bed, as he calls it - it's mostly admin and paperwork though.

There's a private tank in his office too (big surprise, I know, but Angella had banned him from setting up more in the house.) Catra takes her lunches in there sometimes when it's empty and watches the discus milling about.

Anyway, it's close to noon when said manager reappears.

"So... Catra." He drifts up to the counter where she's sat, and something about his demeanor makes her want to bolt - it's all false nonchalance.

"Micah," Catra nods dutifully, before ducking back down to her phone (so what, there's like, three customers around and she's pretty certain they're not intending to buy, anyway), plus she's kinda alarmed at where this conversation is gonna go. Maybe she can stumble across a news article about the wonders of how Goldfish recognise human faces and completely derail interest from his original line of questioning. She makes a mental note then to send that paper through to Adora too, she'd probably find it interesting...

He interrupts that thought process to probe, "How are you, how are things?" *Subtle Micah, well done.* But he sounds so genuinely interested in her endeavors that for a split second she actually wants to spill the beans. (The date, the beans about the date. She went on a really fucking wonderful *date* yesterday) She clamps her jaw shut instead.

She chooses to say, taking her time over the words. "I'm good, great, thanks for asking."

Micah beams like the sunrise, the dork. "Well, that's just wonderful Catra, I'm very happy for you."

Glimmer ’s obviously been loud mouthing —Catra finds it hard to care, and also finds herself smiling completely against her own will like a goddamn sap. She wonders what Adora’s been gushing to her friend about their day together that’s been passed along like a game of telephone till it’s reached Micah, making his eyes glint like something shiny from the bottom of Brightmoon bay . She scoffs dramatically, rolling her eyes as her cheeks begin to flush. It’s supposed to replace the dopey look on her face with mirth but it doesn’t work as intended. Mostly she probably looks flustered, she thinks. Like an idiot with a crush. (She is, btw .)

“I’ll leave you to it then,” he says, taking one step in the direction of the office. “Everyone fed and checked over?”

“Duh.”

He sends awkward finger guns in her direction as he walks backward. “That’ s why you’re employee of the month!”

She rolls her eyes again. “W e all know that’s an empty gesture here.” He just circulates the honor between the five members of staf f so no one gets left out. It’s practically a participation trophy.

Micah pouts. “But you’re all so wonderful, what else would you have me do?”

“Hm.” Catra leans back in her chair . “Gonna need something to sweeten the deal a lil bit.”

He considers that, and then of fers. “W e’ve got more clowns coming in next week. Ill let you have first pick.”

Catra stills, narrowing her eyes at him. “What kind?”

“Picassos,” Micah is a fucking awful facilitator , but his collection’s larger than her own. “I know you have a spot free for a pair .”

And how is she supposed to say no to that?

"Hey, hi, you're here," Adora greets in an endearing, red-faced rush when she opens the door that evening.

"Hey, yourself." Catra returns.

Adora just kinda lingers there for a few moments, as though forgetting to step back to give Catra space to enter. She pushes past her, bemused, closing the door as she does (it's cold, dude).

It clicks shut. Adora's still staring.

They're left standing close enough in the hallway that Catra's skin continues to tingle even after the chill wears off. Then ~~a~~nd it's barely noticeable ~~A~~dora tilts forward on the balls of her feet like she's seeking something, before pulling back just as indiscernibly. The gulp is more obvious though.

It takes Catra a few seconds, and to be fair, she's out of practice, to realize Adora had probably been wanting to kiss her again but is being too bashful to just say so, to say anything, *do* anything.

So, Catra rocks up onto her tiptoes and does it for her.

It's short, there's no squeak of surprise, just a soft hum as Adora leans into her, and then Catra's pulling away, and Adora, dear, sweet Adora, is moving to follow.

Catra places a hand on the blonde's chest, holding her back. "Finn, first."

It's funny that Adora actually makes a disappointed, keening sound.

"You wanna be a good pet mom or what?" Catra cocks an eyebrow, and it's enough for Adora to relent.

"I, um, I started cooking," Adora admits, she's playing with her own hands like she's trying to stop them from reaching out toward her, Catra notices. "You totally don't have to but I'm making enough for two if you wanted to stay for dinner again," Adora swallows thickly. "If you wanted."

Catra smiles, and her expression is shy despite how blasé she's trying to make it. "That would be nice."

"Great!" Adora sends a thumb back over her shoulder down the hall, "Guess I should, uh, head back. I'll be in the kitchen. If you need anything!"

"I'm sure me and Finny will be just fine." She shoos the blonde away, watches her depart, and then moves herself to the living room. A movie is paused on the laptop that's sat on the coffee table - it's the only way Adora watches things, she's learned. It's dark in here as though Adora's been slaving away over the stove ever since the sun set outside the windows. (Autumn sucks). Finn's tank light is on though.

"Sup, Finn," She greets, dumping her bag down by their cabinet. "Hope you don't mind me dating your mom." She glances back over her shoulder to check the coast is clear before she says, quieter. "I think I really, really like her."

They blub a few times in response, and she could swear they're going cross-eyed - she'll take it for indifference.

"Well, okay then. Let's get you sorted."

She pulls out her equipment, confirming after five minutes that there's no further work she'll need to do tonight. Which is fucking fantastic because she really just wants to slob out on the couch for a few hours cuddled up with a warm-bodied *nobody in particular.*

"You enjoying the new digs?" She asks, sticking her whole arm in to reposition a few rocks that don't look quite right with today's eyes.

Despite her earlier comment, she can't just leave it unfixed. "Gotta be better than that pink trash Sparkles threw up all over you. I don't know how your mom could possibly allow her to do that to you, you poor thing."

Someone clears their throat from behind her, and Catra realises a few things in that instant. First, she can be kinda jumpy at times. Second, Adora must be really god damn light-footed when she wants to be because she's standing at the doorway right now. Third, she probably has been for some time because she's got a stupid, fond smile spreading across her face.

"You talking to my fish?" One eyebrow is raised and she looks ridiculously endeared.

"No," Catra scoffs, clears her throat, and then mumbles knowing she's been caught red-handed. "Maybe. Just a little bit."

"Aww."

Catra huffs though it comes out as more of a laugh. "Fuck off."

Adora just beams even wider at her cursing. (Catra thinks they might be soul mates, actually, and that absolutely feral train of thought makes the skin in her cheeks burn even redder.)

Adora's kind enough to change the topic. "Would you like me to make some garlic bread to go alongside—"

"You don't even have to finish that sentence dude, yes, please make garlic bread."

Adora snorts, shifting on her feet to leave again. "Okay, okay."

"But hey," Catra says before Adora's figure disappears behind the wall bordering the hallway to the kitchen, the heat in her cheeks starts to settle. "You got any salad or anything? I've been slacking lately and I gotta keep the old gal ticking over."

"Yeah, of course," Adora nods (she looks like a puppy, Catra thinks, maybe a Newfoundland or something big and goofy and adorable). "There's extra zucchini and chickpeas added to the sauce too, good heart-healthy meal for you!"

"Thanks, you dork."

And it's the best damn chili Catra's ever had.

Catra stretches out post-meal longways over the couch, her lower legs in Adora's lap and her head propped up on the armrest. Blankets are draped over them both. A film is playing on the mini screen perched on the coffee table, but she's mostly paying attention to the thumb that's circling over the skin of her ankle. She's honed in like a sonar. It's all she can concentrate on, think about, *feel*, she kind of wants to kick Adora's hand away to get her to stop so she can pay enough attention to the movie to work out what it is they're even watching.

They get about twenty minutes through the film while Catra has her silent crisis and then she hears Adora's voice. "Is it rude if I want to ask you more about your heart thing?" She wonders if Adora's been paying equal attention to the plot.

In all seriousness, Catra examines the blonde's face to find her sincere and ardent. "Shoot." Her voice is a bit croaky, but Adora's hand has stilled now.

"Did they—did the doctors know immediately?" She asks. "As soon as you were born?"

Catra nods, the noise from the speakers drains into the background. "I mean, pretty much yeah. It's one of the first things they check you

for, stethoscope to the chest to monitor for any irregular rhythms."

"So you had a heart murmur?"

"Y up." She lets the P pop. "Congenital heart defect, super fun, wouldnt recommend. Anyway, they had to open up my chest to sort out the mess of my aortic valve, which is a fucking delight because not only do they slice open your skin but they have to crack open a few ribs to be able to reach into it. So everything aches for weeks."

"And you were five?"

"Five on my last one," Catra confirms. The film might as well not exist anymore, had Adora paused it at some point? She's not certain. "Pretty sure the whole experience made me addicted to morphine for a few years, but whatever."

Adora takes a few seconds, possibly mulling over if she's being serious or not. There's no hyperbole there, but if Adora's not gonna push... "And what's the scar like, is it obvious?"

"Oh yeah." Catra nods sagely, her smirk a bit weak. "Freaked some girls out when I forgot to tell them in time. I mean, it healed well, but I guess if it's unexpected, it's a lot to take in all at once. It is kinda… *there*. But I guess after a while of having it, I tend to forget it's weird. It's just me, you know?"

"Y eah," Adora replies, soft, then. "That's lame of them though, I've always thought scars were pretty rad."

"Y ou got any?" Catra inquires, wanting a change of topic from her own boobs.

"Y eah!" Adora pipes up like they're twelve and asking each other about their pokemon card collections. "I have some on my back. From the crash. There was a lot of, um, glass."…

Catra pulls her legs towards her and sits up slowly, noticing how Adora's gone foggy-eyed despite her tone of voice. "It's alright Adora, we don't have to"—

"Can I show you?" She responds instead, the question takes Catra aback.

She nods tightly, swallows.

Adora pulls her t-shirt over her head and twists away so her skin's more visible to Catra, she's in nothing but a sports bra underneath but it's not so revealing as to have Catra suddenly flustered. She's more interested in the blemishes in Adora's flesh. They're mostly shallow, ripples dotted around her shoulders and down to the center of her spine, scattered as surely as the freckles over her skin. "Raz told me she was there holding my hand while they spent an hour pulling the fragments out of my back."

Catra lets a thumb brush over the marks. And then the whole flat of her hand, ghosting over them like she's mapping constellations. "How much of it do you remember?" She asks, soft.

"Nothing," Adora replies even softer. "I remember them, my family, or at least, remember that I had one. But I don't remember when it happened. Trauma buried it, I guess, and it was a long time ago."

Catra lets out a sad smile and Adora catches the last traces of it as she pivots in her seat back toward her

Catra's not sure where the bravery comes from, perhaps it's Adora leading the way, but she finds herself pulling her own garments off over her head. She's never undressed herself in front of another girl and had it feel this overwhelmingly intimate, while simultaneously not sexual *at all*. It's a new experience.

Adora's eyes immediately settle on Catra's scar, it's not hard to find. A good chunk of it is hidden within her cleavage, but a blunt, white

line splits the upper part of her diaphragm. Catra swallows down a lump in her throat.

She kinda wants to let Adora touch it like she'd done with her ~~but~~ she thinks that might be traversing the tone of what this moment is, and Adora doesn't ask, so she leaves it be.

Adora's eyes observe her for a while, and she's not blushing, so Catra's more confident she's not reading the room wrong.

"You're beautiful." Adora all but whispers.

That has Catra's cheeks flushing with complete disregard to their level of undress. She scoffs, "yeah well, so are you." She adds, because her heart is racing like a war drum. "I guess."

Adora lets out this agonising, teary-eyed, but completely honest smile "I'm here."

And then she's holding her arms open in invitation and Catra's escaping into them like they're sanctuary she didn't know she was searching for.

She feels arms loop around her waist but she thinks she might be leaving indents in the shape of crescent moons where her nails are clutched into the flesh of Adora's shoulders. The blanket over her lap falls partially away but she doesn't need it when she's got the heat from Adora's body right against her.

They stay like that. A minute, another, Catra considers pulling away but something in her screams in objection to the mere thought. Her eyes feel like they're leaking ~~it~~ it's probably just allergies (it's autumn), so she rubs her cheeks against Adora's collar bones to hide the tear stains.

Catra's voice is husky when she asks, "what are we doing?"

"Uh, hugging?" Adora's chest vibrates as she speaks.

"No," Catra's laugh is equally as hoarse as she loosens her arms, returns to her side of the couch, and wipes the back of her hand over her cheeks. "What are we doing? What is all this emotional vulnerability bullshit?" She sniffs wetly. "Ugh, I hate it."

Concern is etched into Adora's face for a heartbeat before Catra lets out a watery chuckle. "You're turning me into a sappy old fool, Catra." She wraps her arms around herself then, but it's because of the goosebumps forming on her arms and not because she's half-naked.

Adora passes over her clothes regardless and helps Catra when her arms get stuck trying to get both her tee and hoodie back on at the same time because they'd sorta stuck together when she'd pulled them off. It's not the best plan, she realises, but Adora helps her straighten it out before putting her own clothes back on too. How disgustingly domestic.. *(*Catra might be getting addicted to it though.) And wow, what the fuck, it's been barely a week when she thinks about it.

Catra's insides are like the calm after a storm stuck on a boat while you're just feeling the gentle rock of the waves and learning how to breathe once more. As though, if she were to stand now, she'd find her feet unsteady.

Catra slips her hands between her knees to warm them.

Then, as if noticing, Adora moves to drape the layered blankets around both their shoulders like a cloak, and the movie starts again with them both sat in comfortable silence. *Oh, so she had paused it. Huh.*

Catra spends the rest of the film stealing glances towards Adora's face and the way the light from the laptop reflects in her warm, blue eyes. She still feels like she needs to cry a little, so she does, but neither of them mentions it out loud — and she's certain the watery look that glazes over Adora's too isn't lying to her.

Their hands find each other’s at some point, their bodies touching from shoulder to heel where theyŕe sat so close together . They dont really speak again till they share an unhurried goodbye as Catra’s heading out the door.

And she still couldnt tell you what theyd watched.

Chapter 5

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra finds Adora's hoodie hung up at the back of her closet on Friday evening;a splash of red amongst her other garments that her hand gravitates towards, pulling it to the forefront. She kinda forgot she even had it, honestly. Adora cant mind the absence though. She hasnt asked for it back.

She mustve left it lying about the flat somewhere because Scorpia's evidently washed the thing and left it neatly amongst her others, which is sacrilegious, because, when Catra puts it on, it no longer smells like Adora -and instead like lavender and lilac and roses or whatever the fuck Perfuma mixes in with her home-brewed laundry detergent.

If Catra's got her nose pressed into the fabric trying to discern some remnant, then only her wardrobe stands as witness.

She huffs. Mostly at her own damn ridiculousness (she's a little drunk, forgive her). However, after an evening spent with her friends in some downtown bar shed never heard the name of before (Mermista's recommendation) she thinks she's just found the perfect thing to snuggle into, and, so long as it's Adora's, itll do just fine.

Feeling floaty and warm from the aforementioned alcohol, she pads out of her room on bare feet through the apartment. Her room is too empty. Her bed just looks too cold right now for what she needs.

Scorpia swivels in her chair when the bedroom door creaks open, her computer's running a game Catra cant place. But that's unimportant details.

She flomps down onto her best friend's bed, her back sinking into miles of bedding as she does so. It's cozy and comfortable here, like a warm, weightless cloud.

Maybe she's falling asleep.

Her friend's voice catches her attention and her eyes blink open again as she picks up an amused, "You doing alright there, wildcat?"

"Mmhmm." Catra nods, her voice a little hoarse – despite the fact she rarely seeks refuge in Scorpia's room like this unless she has something to get off her chest. A bit of emotional rubble, maybe a whole mountain.

Her roommate's eyes flicker over the hoodie Catra's wearing and the obvious fact it's unfamiliar and engulfing Catra's frame, the sleeves reaching down to her fingernails on each hand.

It's not a particularly challenging inference.

Scorpia props one arm over the backrest of the chair, then her chin on her forearm. "You've been spending an awful lot of time with Adora recently."

"Yeah." Catra acknowledges, reaching for one of the hundreds of throw pillows on the bed, she starts running her fingers through the velvety tassels. "And you spend an awful lot of time with Perfuma, so what?"

"Perfuma's my girlfriend," Scorpia notes. Which is like, a super helpful observation.

"And Adora's my." Catra flounders pathetically. "My. Adora."

"Aww."

Catra nearly hurls the cushion at her. "Shut up!"

Scorpia coos. "I would do, but I'm pretty sure you came in here for a reason. Still waiting on that, bud."

Catra grumbles something so incoherent even she can't distinguish it, instead, she opts to drop the pillow over her face and expects herself to scream into it (though she's not sure what would be fueling it, exactly.) No sound comes out though, so she supposes there's no mystery to solve.

She reveals her face again slowly. Scorpia smiles gently at her but makes no move to return to her game even though the conversation clearly isn't going anywhere fast. "Have you invited her over here yet?"

"No," Catra admits.

"You can do, I don't mind, I can be out if you like."

She shoots a glance toward her friend. "I don't want to put you out on the curb like that."

"You wouldn't be, I can organize to stay at Fuma's. Double date from two opposite ends of town." She wiggles her eyebrows. "I'm sure Adora would love to see your tanks. And meet Melog."

"Hm." She doesn't *disagree*. "Where is the old fleabag?"

"Napping in the bathtub, last time I checked."

"What a weirdo."

"I know." Scorpia agrees, nodding her head sagely.

Catra's hands return to the threads dangling from the corners of the cushion as though they're a lifeline, as her cheeks turn pink as cherry blossoms and her heart rate noticeably picks up in her sternum.

She takes a breath. "Hey, Scorp?"

"Yeah, bud?"

"How did you know you were in love? With Perfuma." She's devotedly looking down at her hands and the individual stitching along the hemlines now, she wonders if this one was hand-made by one of Scorpia's moms.

"Oh, wow, uh." A quick glance proves her friend's not going to mock this time. "It's hard to put into words, I guess. It's a lot. I, um," she pauses. "I'm not really the best at putting feelings into words in a way that makes sense, you know that."

Catra deflates a little where she's laying.

"But I do know," Scorpia continues, her tone warm and kind. "That if you're even ready to use that word. Then there's at least a tiny bit of truth in that."

Catra flushes all the way to her ears as she scoffs. "It's not even been two weeks yet."

Scorpia's hands raise in surrender. "Choice of topic's all on you, dude."

Catra harumpfs loudly as her nose scrunches and she yanks a little too hard at one of the tassels, causing a string to come free.

"You know," Scorpia begins, not seeming to mind that Catra's destroying her bedding. "There's supposed to be a test for that."

"A test for what?"

"For figuring out if you actually *like*, like someone or if it's just an infatuation caused by proximity," Scorpia explains.

One of Catra's eyebrows inches upward. "And what would that be?"

"I think the concept goes that you spend an equal amount of time *not* seeing each other as you have been together. So in your case,

you've spent two weeks practically glued at the hip, so you'd spend two weeks apart." Scorpia shrugs. "Distance would either make the heart grow fonder, or you'd get bored and move on. Or something like that."

Catra cocks her head, observing the ceiling now. Could she go that long without seeing Adora, or, which was probably the more pressing question did she even want to? Not see her in person, or not communicate at all?

Scorpia ponders this, and the reply she gives sounds like she's been spending too much time around Entrapta. "I guess you'd get more clear-cut data if you don't talk at all. But you wouldn't want to be mean about it."

Catra mulls this over, two weeks isn't particularly long for a research project and she thinks as long as she has her phone to communicate she's not gonna get heartsick from longing. (How dramatic, eww.) But, if there's a chance she can cure herself of this *being so lonely for a person that she crawls into their clothes when she's the slightest bit drunk* then she kinda wants to try. She pointedly ignores that having Adora within the bed Catra returns to tonight would be as much of a remedy. "Okay, so no seeing her, minimal texts, for two weeks, and then we review?"

Her friend blinks, comes to her senses, as though surprised Catra's actually forging ahead with this. "I mean, you could just spend those two weeks hanging out with her and enjoying her company and seeing where that takes you? You know." She lets out an uncomfortable laugh. "It was just a dumb suggestion."

"You've never suggested anything dumb in your life."

"Catra." Scorpia's eyes try to catch her own to indicate the sincerity of the warning there.

"What?" She lets them, holding the gaze.

Her friend sighs loudly. "Just, be careful, okay? Don't get anyone hurt."

"I won't." Catra returns, letting out a tipsy grin. "Pinky promise."

Catra wakes and immediately sobers to the realisation she's committed to this experiment.

She adds something to the fine print there and then: no phone calls. None. Zero. Because the sound of Adora's voice will undoubtedly be the thing that makes her cave in.

She also wears Adora's hoodie to work on Monday. So, a good start to the weaning off of her front. They swap a few messages over the weekend, but it's a painless start because Adora's out of town, so she can't even tempt Catra with the question *are you free?*

Tuesday is a different matter though.

So far, she has been lucky. Like, Adora *knows* where she works, and it wouldn't be the first time the blonde showed up unannounced. It hasn't happened yet. But a message drops into her inbox as she's dumping her bags onto her bedroom floor and greeting Melog who's curled up in a ball at the foot of her bed. She sits perched on the edge of the mattress, scritching the cat under his chin as she scrolls through the text, enjoying the purr against her hand.

Do you have any plans for tomorrow evening?

Catra swallows down the lump in her throat and the itch in her fingertips to immediately reply *no.* Instead, she says, after some thought. *Sorry, got a hospital thing.*

Adora replies quickly, the sweetheart. *You okay?*

Yeah, just boring check-up stuff, no biggie. Which is only a little lie because she actually does have one booked in for Thursday lunchtime. Procedural nonsense, the usual.

You want company?

Nah, pretty boring stuff. Be in and out in five minutes.

No worries, I hope it goes well! Adora returns, followed by a smiley face and a pink heart - which, *ouch.*

Catra pauses as she tries to stop her heart fluttering at the sight of it, and then replies. *Yeah, me too, haha.* (Her own lacks the emoj, she thinks that's for the best) Her nonchalance is mostly performative but the other options aren't nearly as fun - the app on her phone that can ping the location of the nearest defibrillator at any given time isn't just for show though.

Adora, thank god, doesn't suggest an alternative day. A few more messages flitter back and forth and suddenly Catra realises it's 12pm and she should sleep if she's gonna have the energy to wake up in time to make breakfast before work tomorrow. Which fails, unsurprisingly.

They both fall asleep just after midnight with stinging eyes and sunlight in their chests.

So, yeah, good start.

Catra's friendship circle group chat is a little bit insane. It's mostly Entrapta's fault, she's always argued. It's kept muted on her phone

for the most part as anything important gets filtered through Scorpia anyway, so when her flatmate announces that Mermista's invited them out to the beach house that weekend, Catra cautiously opens up the chat for the first time in a few weeks.

Merms is aware she doesnt interact much on the main group and appears to have dropped her a dm as well to compensate. How thoughtful.

Sup bitch

we're doing a beach day sat

wanna join?

heard you got a new girl, you can bring her too if you want

be nice to meet her, or whatever

Catra grins, her eyes rolling towards the heavens before she replies. *Sure, sounds cool, me and Scorp are down*

Mermista's reaction comes through a split-second alter. *no gf?*

she's not my girlfriend, besides, trying to detox

oh?

not working out?

it's working out

way too fucking well

Merms replies a simple and all comprehensive. *Ah*

Yeah

See you saturday then, ig

Yeah, see you saturday

Catra lets her phone plummet to the bedsheets, Melog's giving her a weird, judgemental look when she turns back toward him.

"What?" She questions, returning the glare, her eyes narrowing.

There's a gentle knock at the front door that steals away his eye contact before she can get an answer though, convenient timing for some. She knows who it is so there's no misgivings in standing to answer, and her bedroom's closer to the entrance anyway—

"I'll get it!" Scorpia insists as she barrels past Catra who' s now mere paces away from the locked door. Catra's certain there's a noticeable breeze as she moves.

"Dude."

"Sorry ." She stage whispers, and then louder to their guest as the door is opened. "Hi!"

"Hi yourself." Perfuma beams, a small rubber mat curled up under one arm, she peers over Scorpia's broad shoulder then. "Hello, Catra."

She sends a mock salute back. "Sup." She elbows the taller girl in the side lightly. "Y ou gonna let my yoga instructor in or what?"

"Absolutely , of course!" She finally steps back, nearly plastering herself against the wall, and waves her arm in a 'come in' gesture.

Perfuma's smiling fondly as they advance into the appartment. "Will you be joining us today , Scorpia?"

"Oh, no, it' s not really my thing, but I love to watch!" She says, then fumbles, and flushes bright red like a raw flame. "Not—I—didnt mean "—

"Thank you for hosting today , Catra." Perfuma politely covers for the slip-up that would've had Freud scribbling frantically in a journal. "The ambiance of your living room works so much better for sessions." She leads them through the living room with the grace of someone who's been here a million times. "I've been considering getting a tank for the studio actually." The mat gets rolled out over the carpet beside Catra's maroon one that's been waiting there. "What are your rates?"

Catra startles. "My rates?"

"Well, naturally I have no idea about keeping aquariums, I know from what Scorpia's explained that it's a lot more complicated than most people realise. I'd be more confident if you were the one looking after them for me." Perfuma sits cross-legged. "Now that we own a few more locations, we have the extra income to put toward sprucing the space up a bit, I thought a water feature would be particularly beneficial for our meditation groups."

"Holy fuck yes, I'd be *thrilled* to," Catra joins her on the floor . "What sort of budget are we talking?"

Melog is sat on her phone, it takes her half an hour to realise, but she gets ready for bed in the meantime so it's not minutes lost. He complains as though she's asking him for his liver as she pulls it out from under him, reclining onto her back with the device casting a glow over her face. Melog re-positions himself right next to her face atop her pillow so he can't be that mad about the theft.

Adora texted her . About two hours ago.

Can I see you on Saturday?

Catra bites her lip, her hands hesitating ~~it~~ takes her far too long to type out. *Can't*

Got plans with the beach

Adora's immediately active. *Sunday?*

Gonna be super hungover babe, sorry

Catra waits but there's no continuation despite the fact their more recent conversations have gone on for hours. Something in her sternum sinks a little. It's probably for the best that she gets at least one good night's sleep, she tells herself.

Catra fucking hates hospitals. Scorpia tells her it's understandable, and despite numerous offers, she sits out in the waiting room alone for her name to be called, her hands trembling in her lap.

She's skipping from her car all the way to the front door when she arrives home an hour later though. Scorpia's in the living room.

"Guess who's heart is nothing to be concerned about at present? that's right. This gal." Catra thumbs towards herself, before leaping over the arm of the couch and settling into the seat cushions.

"Catra." Scorpia scowls at her.

"What, we found this piece of junk off the side of the road. It's not like I'm gonna damage it more than it already is." She rolls her eyes playfully before nudging her friend with her foot. "Aren't you gonna congratulate me?"

"Adora came to the store today," Scorpia says instead, and why does she look so fucking fidgety?

Catra feels her whole body brace. "She did?"

"Yeah." She continues. "In the morning – she was looking for you, didn't realise it was your day off, I guess. She asked how your appointment went. Which was weird, because you hadn't had it yet, obviously."

She can feel her own face grow cold and pale. "Scorp"…

"Um," She shuffles in her seat. "You told her it was booked for Tuesday?"

Catra's jaw locks. "Yeah"…

"Okay, so," Scorpia's hands raise in surrender. "I understand you're doing your whole distancing thing, and I'm not gonna judge, but I didn't realise you were *lying*, and when I corrected her and said you were with me and Perfuma on Tuesday evening, she kinda" It's a fucking ominous pause.

"Kinda *what*?" Catra's hand is gripping white-knuckled onto the armrest now.

"She got a bit upset? I think?" Scorpia explains in a rush. "It was hard to tell, she left pretty quickly after that."

"Ugggh, *shit*." Catra grumbles as her head falls into her hands. "Shit!" She prays that this isn't an irreparable fuck up. "Did you give any impression that maybe it had been rescheduled, any room for interpretation?"

"Yeah, no." Scorpia shakes her head regretfully. "I said I knew it was Thursday and always had been because you schedule hospital stuff for days off so you can decompress after and"—

"Shit. *Fuck.*"

"I'm so sorry, Catra."

She scrambles to find her phone. "It's fine Scorp, this isn't your fault."

She pings a text through desperately. *Can I see you tonight?*

Adora's reply is slow but the device tells her she's seen the message. *Are you wanting to collect Finn's old tank?*

A pathetic noise escapes the back of Catra's throat before she returns. *No, forget the tank*

I really don't mind, it's easier than disposing of it myself

Her heart drops into the ground, through the planet and beyond the stratosphere out the other side. *Forget the goddamned tank, I want to see you*

She watches those three blue dots for what feels like an eternity. *Tomorrow? Tonight's not the best for me*

Tomorrow's perfect

Chapter End Notes

> So I am still writing this, I'll just be slow because life is crazy for me right now

Chapter 6

Chapter Notes

> Thank you Sydney for your help with this fic and my personal life, you've had such a valuable input on how this turned out, and been such a great support system to get it finished ❤❤

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra's always had trouble admitting her mistakes. It's one of her worst mortal transgressions, but there's no deceiving herself from the fact she's fucked up something precious and delicate and perfect. What the hell was she thinking?

It's raining outside. Despite her personal troubles and internal gutwrenching, stupid, fucking anguish, work still exists as something she has to do.

She could have called in sick. But then Micah would have worried and questioned and turned up with soup on her doorstep or something. So, instead, she's sat by the checkout grumbling as she listens to the storm pelt down on the roof of the building. Electricity is still on, the weather's not tumultuous enough for that to be a concern, though with a shop full of tanks and filters and heaters hooked up to the mains supply it sure would be a hell of a problem. Still, not as much of a calamity as she's found her love life in.

Was it really love? Would she have done this if it was?

Her phone is quiet, the few she'd sent Adora through the day remain unanswered, on seen.

I'm sorry

And

I've been a massive idiot but I can explain

kind of

And

you'll think it's really stupid

which, it is

Can you please reply to me? I'm really sorry

It's around lunchtime when she gets a response, though it doesnt confirm anything more than was already set in stone. *Come at mine?*

She accepts she's pressing fortune's limits to even be allowed to talk in person, so she shuts her phone down to stop herself from pestering any further. It's a quiet day. Trade tends to slow down in grey, wet weather so there's no surprise. The koi fish outside dont seem particularly perturbed.

An ache emanates from deep within her sternum that she thinks she can recognise as heartbreak, she doesnt deserve to be the one feeling like this though, so she smushes that thought down to the shady parts of her brain still in denial.

He had tried to ask if she was feeling okay earlier. Her scowl was a quick memo to avoid asking that question possibly *ever* again.

The bell over the front doorbell chimes. Someone walks in with the hood of a raincoat obscuring their face and it's only when they pull the sodden material down that Catra recognises those features. Second hand, only through a particular someone's photos pinned by magnets to her fridge door.

She sits up straight and clears her throat apprehensive as he approaches the counter. A deliberate path straight towards her. Great.

"You're Bow ." She acknowledges stiffly in greeting. They've never met in person before but he's one of Adora's very few favourite people in the world, so it's hard *not* to know exactly who he is. Acquaintances by osmosis, or whatever.

"I am." His voice is deeper than expected, sedate. She wasn't expecting a jolly debut given the circumstances, but she'd watched the storm roll in that morning from the coastline, calm and deep and grey as an abyss, and that same energy is standing before her now.

Catra swallows, her voice catches. "I assume you're here to tell me I've been a colossal bitch."

He winces, surprisingly . "It's good to know you recognise you've not been particularly nice, but I wouldn't have phrased it quite like that."

"Your girlfriend would have."

"No doubt." He agrees too calmly . "Glimmer wanted to come here, actually. I managed to talk her off that ledge — I don't think it would have done either of you any good."

"So, you're here?"

"It was a compromise."

Catra fidgets in her chair. "If you're not here to yell at me, then why are you?"

"Because there's something that doesn't make sense to me in all this." He takes a respectably calm breath before he explains. "I know we've never met, and yeah, maybe Glimmer isn't painting the best picture of right now. But Adora told us about the first day you went to her apartment. That you brought her ice cream just because she'd sounded upset over the phone and how you offered to help her for free despite it being unpaid overtime — and I just can't reconcile how someone could behave like and be a—" He collects himself and she gets the impression the next few words out of his mouth are a quote

from a specific pink-haired, she-devil. "good for nothing, piece of shit, asshole."

Catra can feel herself recoil. "Sparkles really said that?"

"Yes." "At least he's honest, bless him. But mostly because Adora was crying at the time and she was trying to be a supportive friend."

That pain in her chest splits open like a chasm. "She's been crying?"

He considers her for a moment before his reply. "She was very fond of you, Catra. I think she'd convinced herself you'd gotten bored of her and didn't know how else to say it."

Catra's mouth opens to reply, but she finds the effort of it stuck right at the back of her throat. She watches him take note of the probable absolute anguish over her face. The storm clouds dissipate behind his eyes and the forecast changes to partial sunshine by the time she's brave enough to look into them again.

"You know, Adora doesn't have a lot of… *people* here." He begins unfairly soft. "For a long time, it was just me, Glimmer, and her grandma. When Razz passed away... honestly, for a while there I was really scared about how she would handle the grief. But then she met you." He says, and it's the first time he's smiled at her. "After spending just a few weeks with you she lit up in a way I'd never witnessed before." A pause, it feels as heavy as a mountain. "You were making her happy, Catra."

Catra replies with her voice a mere decibel above a whisper. "She was making me happy too."

There's another small smile. "Okay. Well, *that's* why I'm here. Because I think if the two of you would stop being such stupid lesbians about this, it could be something really special. And I want Adora to have that way more than I want to kick your ass right now."

Catra chuckles, the sound comes out broken and watery. "I'm—I'm trying to make things better. I need to explain it in person or it will sound really...pathetic, I wanted to see her last night but I guess she was busy or...something." She shrugs, her gaze falling down to the countertop, *through* it.

Bow smiles sympathetically. "We were with her last night. She called us round to console in us about what had happened, but she spent most of the evening in tears. She seemed pretty set on her interpretation of events—Glimmer wasn't helping either—, and of course, I didn't know you well enough to want to make a judgment call." He takes a breather, they're both in need of it. Tentatively, he inquires. "Can I ask? What happened?"

Catra shrugs. "Would you accept adoptive generational trauma and a whole lot of dumbassery?"

Bow frowns minutely. Catra considers honesty and then shakes her head. "I will explain to Adora, if she wants to tell you after, then that's up to her."

"That's fair." Bow concedes. "But just know, that when you do share your reasoning with my best friend, whatever it is, if she makes the decision not to forgive you, don't expect me to be so civil next time we meet."

Catra gives him a faux-salute, her hand with a barely noticeable tremor. "Gotcha."

"See you around, Catra." He says, returning the salute, before exiting the shop back out into the patter of rain. She watches him leave, remembering how Adora always stopped to smile at the pond fish on her way out, and a fissure splits inside her ribcage.

It has to be love, doesn't it? Why else would it hurt like this?

Catra brings Ben and Jerry's. She's got phishfood and chocolate fudge brownie because she's not sure which is Adora's favorite but she's happy to have either, and she's certain theyll both be needing it. Maybe the irony could be an icebreaker too.

Her hand hesitates before she knocks on the door;there's a perfectly good bell to the left but using something so mechanised when she's shown up here prepared to pour her soul out just seems counterintuitive somehow. *Here I am, it's me.* And she hopes the beginning of her apology comes through with how softly her knuckles rap against the door frame.

Adora folds her arms into herself after she opens it. It's not a defensive stance, it's sunken inward, hollow. "...Hi."

"Hi." Catra's not sure what else to say so she offers the ice cream with her hands stretched out in front of her. "Peace of fering? Take your pick."

She reaches out slowly for the brownie option but blinks distantly at the tub in her hands afterward.

"Can I come inside?"

Adora glances over her own shoulder as though she's forgotten the concept of inside exists. "Yeah." She clears her throat. "Uh, of course."

They move toward the living room, Adora disappears just as Catra dumps her bag by her feet and settles on the couch like a passerine prepared to take flight at any moment. *Gonna get some spoons,* she explains.

"Bow visited me today," Catra starts when she returns, it's nice and easy, her voice comes out husky anyway. "He said you—That you seemed to think I'd gotten bored of you, or something?"

Adora won't meet her eyes, she keeps looking everywhere *other* than back at her. Slowly prying the lid off the ice cream, she begins, her throat bobbing. "I just, um—I want to apologise, first of all, for being so ridiculous about the last few days."

Catra blinks heavily a few times. "What—"

"I mean, obviously you're allowed to see your friends, you're allowed to have other plans, a life, you're allowed to not want to see me, I get that." Adora begins rambling. "I was obviously pressing and pressing to take up more of your time and that was selfish of me, and so, you know, obviously you're not just automatically gonna feel about me how I feel about you and now I've put that weight on you as being something you'd feel like you have to fix, when really it was just me being dramatic and getting ahead of myself and expecting way *too* much, which is unfair on you because—"

"*Adora*." Catra interrupts, water welling in her eyes. "You—You're *allowed* to be upset. I blew you off repeatedly with no valid reason, you're completely justified in being angry at me—what I did was really goddamn thoughtless."

Her smile is pained. "But Catra, it's *okay*. I've been thinking about it a lot today and I figured out the reason why I was hurting was because I misread the situation. I thought what you were feeling for me was different to what you actually were, and it hurt that it felt like I'd lost that, when actually it was never there in the first place and I was being greedy in wanting something you didn't have to give—"

"Oh for fuck's sake, Adora." Catra stands, pacing over the faded carpet. "You weren't *wrong,* okay? I was falling head over heels for you so fast it was mortifying, I wasn't functioning properly all I could think about was you."

"You—" Adora blinks. "What?"

Catra laughs, though it's mostly fueled by hysteria. The palms of her hands meet her face and she groans into them like some truly

exasperated creature. Adora's watching her closely when she emerges, eyes right on her.

"I was falling in love with you." She says, her voice as soft as Adora's eyes are watching her now. "It *terrified* me. I thought taking a break from seeing you would help slow this down so that I could start feeling like myself again rather than some love-sick, mopey idiot, but obviously that didn't work and I ended up hurting you in the process. And it was so fucking stupid of me. I'm so, so sorry, Adora."

Adora's eyes have misted over. "You were falling in love with me?"

Catra nods, because it's the only reply she can give, before she fills her lungs and lets them deflate slowly. And then, "Look, I know Sparkles and I don't get along all that great, but she's not wrong about me."

"About what?"

"That I can be an asshole," Catra explains. "A major A-grade asshole, and yeah, maybe I could blame it on all the baggage left over from Weaver but at the end of the day it's still *me* and I don't—" She realises she's started pacing again. "I don't do this sort of thing, Adora." Her hand moves to indicate the space between them, and then flexes a few times unconsciously to ease the tension coiling through her limbs. "I'm not good at it."

"Feelings?"

Catra huffs heatlessly. "Yeah."

"Well," Adora starts, her voice unsteady, her whole body has folded inward at this point like a creature trying to protect its vital organs. "You might have noticed, I'm not particularly good at it either."

Catra snorts dismissivly. "In what possible way? You did nothing wrong."

f" Adora begins, then retreats further into herself. A few beats pass before she speaks again and it allows the coil in Catra's chest to unwind. "Can I have a few days? T o process this. I think it's gonna take some time, to, um"…

"Y eah." Catra snif fs loudly, whipping the back of her hand over her cheeks even though she's adamant she'd find no wetness there. "Of course. Sorry. Ill get out of your hair ." She moves to fetch her bag, Adora's hand catches her wrist as she does so – it sends a tingle zipping up the length of her arm.

"Just" Adora starts, and then appears to detour midcourse. "I'll contact you, when Im"…

Catra stares at the ground, incapable of retuning the sincerity behind Adora's expression. "Y eah. I get it. Enjoy the icecream, I guess." But then she's leaving out into the fresh air and a pink evening sky, slamming her car door shut too fiercely as she goes.

All things considered, that could have gone a hell of a lot worse.

Catra's phone is lonely over the next few days. Three, five, *ten.* Turns out, waiting for someone to message for hours on end really fucking sucks. But, Adora asked for time, and after everything that's happened, it's the easiest bit of courtesy that Catra can return in favour.

She passes the time. Works, goes home, cooks dinner for her and her flat mate, takes part with half a heart in her weekly yoga sessions, she even drags herself to Brightmoon Bay Aquarium one weekend.

It's not the same.

She'd lost a lot of people, growing up. Catra never knew her family, so she thinks that's an analytical outlier – but the data still stands that apart from Scorpia, there's not been a single person she'd *not* wanted to say goodbye to that hadn't slipped away in the end.

Maybe Adora's just another tally on that chart.

Perfuma tells her she's being silly. The new tank was dropped off at the studio that morning by two burley delivery dudes, already parked up in position against the far wall, so there's no faffing around with it like there was with Finn's new tank. It's big. Maybe even the largest Catra's worked with considering the yoga studio has ample floor space. Fuma hadn't blanched at Catra's invoice breakdown though. She'd coined it a *worthwhile investment* more than just a feature piece, though, if she's really earning the salary from yoga instruction to be able to afford this thing, then why the heck is she giving free sessions to Catra? Whatever, she's not going to complain. She should probably thank her, actually.

"Okay, but it's been nearly two weeks." Catra counters to Fuma's dismissals, her hands working a miracle on the aquascape design as they talk. "Don't you think that's enough of a hint that she's likely moved on and realised I'm too much of a pain in the ass to be dating?"

"I would remind you, that it was exactly that line of thinking on Adora's part that caused you guys to need a break," Perfuma notes. "She'll call you when she's ready."

"Yeah, whatever." Catra huffs, rearranging a lump of dragon stone a few inches to the right. "I'm an impatient person, I don't *like* waiting."

Perfuma lets out this *horrible* smile, it's exceedingly soft. "I find it hard to believe that an impatient person would be willing to spend four hours meticulously decorating an aquarium." She gestures to the tank with a sweeping hand.

Catra glances to the clock on her phone, and *oh*, maybe her friend has a point.

Adora messages two days later. It’s a simple, *Hi.*

Catra nearly has a choking fit on her own cereal and Scorpia sends her a genuinely terrified look for a second before Catra mimes to her phone and flees the room. Privacy for a text conversation isn't really necessary, she’s not sure why she does it, only that now that she has Adora again she wants her all to herself. Sublime logic, she knows.

Hey. Catra returns. She lays down, hoping it will stop her heart from jumping around like a kangaroo.

Can we meet up?

Sure. Catra returns, her thumbs racing over the keyboard. *Do you want to come here? You could meet Melog, and see my collection?*

That sounds wonderful.

Tonight??

Sure.

Scorpia gives her the apartment, she declares she’s spending the night at her girlfriends, smooches Melog on the forehead, then heads out the front door shortly before Adora’s supposed to arrive.

Catra's hands are clammy. She keeps running them over her jeans as she sets herself to cleaning the apartment – an observer might have called it a frenzy , but she's just being thorough, alright?

The knock on the door makes her heart slam against her ribcage like a base drum, her feet carry her swiftly to open it.

Adora's here. Adora's face is right in front of her again and it feels like an eternity since the last time that was true. "Hi, hello." She says too fast like a loser. "Come on in, this is, uh, my home." Her arms branch out awkwardly in a showcase of the humble groundfloor apartment.

"Hi," Adora returns, and Catra's heart lifts to recognise the only emotion in her eyes is endearment.

Adora enters, walking aimlessly into the space until she catches sight of the collection of tanks bordering the living room, and makes a caught-breathed beeline for them. "Oh my god." She whispers under her breath. "They're even prettier in person."

Catra follows, observing closely enough to notice Adora's wideyes expression as she crouches beside the largest and grins at a school of tetras there. "Hello."

Melog yells suddenly from the depths of her bedroom, possibly in response to an unfamiliar voice, but the way he exits, struts towards Adora and head butts her bent knee so forcefully she nearly topples over is pretty in character for him.

Adora catches her balance, voice soft as roasted marshmellows. "Oh, baby , hi." Her hand reaches out for him to sniff before she pets over his ears, he's purring like a locomotive in a thunderstorm. "Aww, you're such a sweetheart."

Catra's heart fucking swoons. God god, she *is* in love with this woman.

"So, um," Catra's voice catches, her hands fidget with the sleeves of her jacket. Maybe its pushy to be so direct but her anxiety wont settle untill the elephant in the room is put out to pasture. "Have you — have you forgiven me now?" For what I did. Can we go back to being." Well, they hadnt ever defined it, so Catra's not sure.

Adora's still loving on the cat and wont quite meet her eyes, Catra swallows thickly.

"I think so." Adora eventually says, and Catra lets out a stunted, shaky breath when their eyes meet again without hesitation. "I know for sure that I was wanting to see you way more than I was upset with you."

"Okay." This is good, Catra can work with this.

"I — I want to try again." Adora explains. "I missed you."

"I missed you too." She thinks that's proved Scorpia's hypothesis, at the very least.

"So, we start again? From scratch?"

"No," Adora replies, and it stops Catra's pulse for a moment. "Not from scratch, these things will happen and it's how we handle them that matters."

"Okay." Catra nods, unfolding her arms from around herself when she realises they've curled around her torso. "Right, use it as a learning experience."

"Exactly." Adora nods, formal, like this is a pilot trial in a lab experiment and not their love life.

Melog yells again before departing to hide under Scorpia's bed, they both watch him leave wordlessly. Then, kinda absently, Adora's eyes turn to the fish again. "These tanks are so cool, I'm jealous."

If their relationship wasn't so unsteady right now, Catra might crack the joke that maybe they'd be in Adora's living room too in a years time. Instead she says cautiously. "Have I shown you Perfuma's new set up?"

"No," Adora stands, dusts her knees and approaches. "You have pictures?"

"Duh," Catra falls back into the couch, beckoning Adora with a 'come here' gesture as she pulls the photos up on her phone. Adora settles in comfortablely beside her.

Catra clears her throat, overly aware of the warm body sitting beside her. "I wanted to go with a dragon stone and juniper wood this time, Perfuma's budget was crazy so it was super fun to go all out on it. I mean," She pauses, zooms in. "Look at that, the driftwood itself cost nearly two-hundred dollars but it looks fantastic and Fuma was super happy." She flicks through a few of the images. "The sadist wants to go for discus and learn how to look after them herself, pfft, we'll see how long that lasts before she decides to pay me to do it forever."

Catra passes Adora the phone to browse. "We haven't even put any fish in there yet and apparently two of her clients have asked for my contact details." Adora's gaze flickers up to meet her's directly. "So I'm psyched about that, it's been less than a week and I'm already branching out beyond friends and family, I really think this could be the start of, um, something—" her voice trails off at the end there when she feels Adora's hand cup around her face, sliding back toward the nap of her neck, the pad of her thumb ghosting over her cheekbone and— *oh*.

Adora's kissing her. Purposefully, as though she's taken chastity out to a ditch in the middle of the night and buried it in the ground.

Catra's a little lightheaded when they pull apart. "Everything okay?" She inquires, flustered, eyes probably as dark as obsidian.

"Sorry ."Adora scrunches up her nose bashfully but she's beaming like the sun. "I really missed you."

Catra smiles back. She doesn't feel the need to repeat the sentiment from before, not when kissing is back on the menu, and her table manners have always been impeccable, thank you very much, but she thinks she's allowed this remission considering she's a woman starved.

Catra's not really sure how yesterday they weren't even speaking to each other and now they've immediately transversed to making out on her living room couch, or why, when Adora shifts, leaning them until Catra's pressed into the cushions underneath her, Catra *lets her*.

She lets her. She thinks that if Adora were to march them down to the courthouse and stand before a ordained priest hand in hand, she'd probably let her do that too.

Wow, the thought isn't even a little bit frightening.

Melog yells at them suddenly. Catra glances to find them inches from her face as Adora jumps back in alarm, but she's soon joining in with Catra's flushed cackle of laughter.

Catra runs a hand over her face and through her hair, finding her cheeks warm against her palms. "Sorry , I think it's his dinner time."

"Oh,"Adora settles onto her haunches, offering Catra a hand to pull her upright too. "How chivalrous. "What about yours"?

Catra starts. "My what"?

"Your dinner. Have you eaten"?Adora inquires, her face soft.

Catra shrugs, glancing down to find Adora's not yet let go of her hand. "I could eat."

"Let me cook for you?" A question, and it has Catra's cheeks turning warm again.

"Um, sure." Catra slips her hand away and holds it in her lap like some consecrated thing.

"Awesome, you sort out Melog and I'll get started." She bounces up onto her feet before she heads to the kitchen.

Catra stands, scoops Melog up like a infant in her arms, he's limp and purring as she walks towards his food bowl. "I hope you're happy having a third mom," She talks quietly to the cat so Adora can't hear as she begins rifling through the cupboards. "I think this one might be sticking around for a while." Melog chirrups in response. Catra has to hide a foolish smile by kissing all over his face when Adora glances casually toward her across the room.

And if she witnessess it regardless, then who the fuck really cares.

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8 Years Later

"This is a joke right?" Catra says, deadpan, she can hear Adora suppress a snicker to her left.

Starla sends her a look over the rim of her glasses, eyes flickering between Catra and her wife where they're sat across the desk from the social worker. She blinks, and the utterly lost expression is the first confirmation that this isn't a prank. "I can assure you, this most

certainly isn't a joke, Mrs Grayskul." It doesn't even matter that that name no longer differentiates between the two of them, because they're both as astonished as each other.

"Let me get this straight." Adora straightens in her chair. "You found us a kid..."

"That's right." Starla nods, her eyes still glazed other with skepticism.

Catra continues, "A real life, actually exists, four year old *child* who is, by some miracle, *not* a ruse orchestrated by one of our friends"—

Adora takes over again. "Who's name is *Finn?"*

"Yes. That is correct." Starla is frowning now like she's questioning the sanity of ever approving the two of them for adoption in the first place.

"I don't believe you." Catra states bluntly, leaning back in her chair, arms crossed.

"I assure you, this is real." She rifles through the documents in front of her, producing the kid's person details and sliding the form across the desk.

There's a photo. Adora eyes stick on it immediately and she lets out a thoroughly smitten 'awww'. Catra's scanning over their full name instead. "No shit. Their name *is* Finn."

"Yes." Starla remains no less perplexed. "You're legally allowed to change their name, of course, if there's some sort of issue with"—

"Nope. No issue." Adora beams, sitting at attention once again. "Right, Catra?"

"I—Yeah, no this is… *wow*."

"Now, as I was explaining on the phone, Finn has a mild heart condition, which is why you were selected in this case—the two of

you were determined the most capable of taking on that particular challenge.” Starla starts the legal drawl of next steps and introductory processes, but Catra's mostly zoning out to the thought process of *this is actually happening* — and it's setting her heart alight like fireflies in the night sky, but also—

All their friends are gonna think they named their first kid after a goddamn deceased goldfish.

It’s a pretty negligible demerit in the grand scheme of things. And when Adora reaches for and squeezes her hand, whispering, ‘you alright?’ Catra’s eyes flicker up from the image of the blonde 4 year old, and she can’t fight off the dopey, lovesick look on her face. “Just try to keep this one alive, okay?” She teases.

Starla splutters and goes pale from the other side of the desk.

Adora rolls her eyes playfully. “I got off to a bad start, but that fish lived to a very respectable old age, thank you very much.”

Catra’s pretty sure she hears their social worker mutter under her breath something along the lines of ‘what the hell is going on’. Before Adora clears her throat, still grinning. “Sorry, Starla, please continue.”

The walk back to the car is quiet. Silence broken only by the unlocking of doors and the click of seatbelts, before Catra glances over her shoulder toward the empty space in the seats behind them.

“What are you thinking?” Adora asks, her eyes watching her attentively.

"Nothing, I just—Is it not weird that in a short amount of time we might actually have a use for those extra seats, that there's gonna be a *kid* sat in the back there."

Adora humms. "I wouldn't call a few months a short amount of time." Funny that it turned out Adora's the more impatient of the two of them.

"I don't know man, those last eight years went by pretty quick for me." She grins like a goof, tipping forward over the gear shift to press a kiss into her wife's cheek.

"Well, Finn will definitely be an upgrade in the rear view mirror than the rocks and pebbles you lug around for work."

Catra lets out a faux gasp. "You'd dare insult an artist's tools? My paints? My easel?"

Adora starts the car, her expression warm and bright as she shakes her head fondly. "I'm not convinced paint would have been any worse than the four kilogram bag of sand you spilled all over the polyester last week, if you do that again, I *will* murder you."

"Aw, good luck getting the adoption to go through while you're waiting on a homicide trial."

"You're an ass."

"And you're the one who put a ring on it, babe."

"God help me."

"Aww, I love you too."

Adora puts the car into drive, and they're merging back onto the street as Catra steals another look around the side of the headrest.

She wonders, as she often does, though it's more and more fleeting now, where the hell she might have ended up had she been too

stubborn to pick up the phone three minutes to clock out. Not here, most likely. But it doesn't matter, because she *is*, and there's never been anywhere else she wants to be.

Chapter End Notes

Hello, I wanted to ask you guys a favour. Those who have been following this fic will know my home life isn't fantastic right now. But the good news is that I'm getting my own place very soon, however, because I've rushed moving out I'm not in a position to be able to afford any furniture or kitchen appliances. This is not an emergency situation in any case, but if anyone were willing to help, or just wanted to give a thank you for the fics I have written, please follow the link on my tumblr page and I would be so god damned grateful.

https://www.tumblr.com/blog/adertilys-quill

Thank you for reading,
Adertily

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